

PARALLEL WORLDS



KEEPING
TREK
PART 2

Mini
of the
Month

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ISSUE #3:

Aliens, Vagrant Workshop, Duchamp Versus Einstein, Earthdawn, budget wargaming, Space Base, Beyond Kidding, Equinox, Homeworld, The Dark Crystal, Terraria, self-published novels, original fiction

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Editorial

It is often said that conversation can be ranked into three tiers: at its most basic, it revolves around people; middling conversationalists discuss events; while the truly interesting discuss ideas.

This is the value of science fiction, fantasy, and horror. Many, many books and films deal with people and their relationships. Uncountable more deal with events. But it is these genres that tackle the biggest ideas.

What does the future hold for our species? What else is really out there? What might our society look like in hundreds of years' time?

The stuff in this issue tackles lots of ideas. We continue our evaluation of the legacy of *Star Trek* and its uniquely optimistic view of the future. We discuss two seminal video games and the universes created for them, and examine the tropes of portraying aliens in games generally. We pan for gold in the torrent of today's self-published literature. We take a look at one of the world's biggest horror film festivals (ok, that's really an event, not an idea). And we have our usual clutch of original fiction; board game, TV, and book reviews; and Mini of the Month.

The response to our first two issues has been brilliant. How best to enjoy them? A full A4 magazine format doesn't translate naturally to every screen. Personally, I like reading it on my tablet. It's about the right shape, and I can pinch to zoom to my heart's content.

This month also sees the launch of the **Parallel Worlds Podcast** — a fully voice-acted audio version of our monthly magazine, expertly edited for listening around the house and while you're on the move. While initially we had planned to make the Podcast a patron-exclusive, we've now decided to make it available to all.

How are we doing, anyway? We'd love to hear from you. Tweet us ([@PWorldsMagazine](https://twitter.com/PWorldsMagazine)) or drop an email to editor@parallelworlds.uk.

Stay fantastic,

Tom

PARALLEL WORLDS

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Feedback

I had a blast reading the second issue. It felt like it was written just for me. I am a fan of *Destiny 2* and I loved reading the article on the new expansion. I will be reading every issue from now on. You have a new fan in me.

— Sam Long

Really hope the magazine does well. I'm not actually much of a fan of board games and the like but the magazine looks terrific and the few articles I've dipped into so far have been a really good read. So many high street mags I've read (*PC Gamer*, *Empire* or various music mags) seem really vacuous — you read them but feel like you learned nothing. **Parallel Worlds** seems different... far more substantial. It's almost as if those high street mags wouldn't dare to give away this much quality in a single article (for fear they'd have nothing left for next month?) Good job everyone!

— Alec Turner

In response to 'Ruling the World: the common sci-fi assumption of 'Government Earth'', featured in Issue 2:

Dave Hutchison's *Fractured Europe* series takes this localised patriotism to an extreme. His Europe is a broken collective, with most of the countries we recognise shattered into smaller and smaller fiefdoms, with borders and spies everywhere. The premise seems the antithesis of *Government Earth*; but of course, there is a bureaucratic force, trying to control all the broken pieces and manage the system.

— Allen Stroud

Through the course of history, forms of human governance have gotten progressively larger. We started out in smaller family groups that grew into tribes, and those tribes became settlements, which became cities, which became states, which became nations. The long arc of progress would seem to indicate that the world headed towards yet more unification.

A number of factors seem to indicate that a war of global conquest is unlikely. Violence, including violence by war, is at its lowest point in human history; indeed, since the end of the Cold War, we have seen a remarkable outbreak of peace in most places in the world. Since the borders between countries were firmly established after WWII, it seems to have become a norm; one that has been violated on occasion, but infrequently. Modernism and global trade have greatly contributed to this.

While nationalism remains an incredibly powerful force among almost all populations, there are indications that it is in fact on the decline, particularly among younger populations. With the rise of the internet and various forms of postmodernism, human consciousnesses are expanding past the limited tribal spheres of our distant ancestors and beyond the nations of our recent forefathers to encompass all the globe. Who can say? Perhaps this arc of progress will bring the world together better than anything we can imagine.

— Ben Potts

Have a thought about anything we said in this issue? Let us know: editor@parallelworlds.uk

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Carsten Damm

CARSTEN DAMM



Every month, **Parallel Worlds** will feature an interview with an amazing content creator or personality working in science fiction, fantasy, or horror. This month, we catch up with roleplaying game creator Carsten Damm, erstwhile lead developer of *Earthdawn*, creator of *Equinox*, and founder of Vagrant Workshop.



Hi Carsten, thanks for talking to **Parallel Worlds**! Can you tell us a little bit about yourself?

Sure thing — I'm as old as the mother of all roleplaying games itself: born in 1974. Not that I started playing right away, though (that didn't happen until the 80s). I'm from Germany, husband to a lovely wife and father of three noisy kids. 'Dammi' has been my nickname since childhood.

Where do you live now? Is there much of a gaming scene?

I've been in Cologne now for almost two decades. It's a nice place to live with an active gaming scene. My current group is mostly about testing various indie games, so we play a lot of different titles.

How did you first get into the gaming hobby?

A friend of mine visited London quite often, and he introduced me to *Warhammer Fantasy Roleplay* way back when. There were just a few other kids playing pen and paper games out there, mostly *The Dark Eye* (our native generic fantasy incarnation of the hobby). *Warhammer* was certainly an odd thing for us at the time: it was a quite mighty hardcover tome and it was written in English. The good thing about the last bit is that my desire to understand the game actually helped me to better understand the language — a sure bonus in school, as far as I recall!

Did you go into games as soon as you left school/university?

It's a hobby first and foremost, and has always been. I went into publishing a few years after leaving university, but I didn't quit my day job.

Was there a particular game that first inspired you to get into games?

I discovered *Earthdawn* in the early 90s, about a year after it came out. It was the first title that really clicked with me. *Earthdawn* inspired me to write, and I discovered that publishing stuff was something I really enjoy doing. So I started to write in English as well as in German — mostly fanwork for *Earthdawn*. A decade later, my reputation and activities opened the door to work as lead developer and editor for two major editions of that game.

You are now the owner and operator behind the Vagrant Workshop and the Pro Indie labels. Could you tell us why you took the leap to forming your own company?

I had a number of side projects while working on *Earthdawn*, and always felt that helping other authors getting published was a good thing to do. I stepped back from working on *Earthdawn* at some point in my career due to different ideas of where to take the company I was working with at the time, so that paved the way for us to move those other titles out on our own label and have a fresh start.

Vagrant Workshop is a small company with an international pool of talent. How do you keep these creative people on track?

Some of them stuck with us after quitting *Earthdawn*, others joined to let their own creative energies vent. The organisation was always very loose, as we took an 'it's done when it's done' approach to everything. We never understood our publishing as a way to make money, but as a hobby we follow with dedication and heartblood. Words, artwork, layout, print prep, project management — all these things functioned quite well and across international borders.

We have an international team too. Do you have a central office or does everyone work remotely?

Remotely. I'd like to refer to my desk as global headquarters, but the truth is that we're working online pretty much all of the time. Meeting up is a rare thing due to the distances involved.



Which of Vagrant Workshop's games do you consider the closest to your heart?

Well, that would certainly be *Equinox* — a future fantasy setting I've imagined doing for a long time.

Equinox was also the first project that the newly established Vagrant Workshop took on. Could you tell us about the development of the game and why it was chosen as the starting point?

Due to my work on *Earthdawn*, *Equinox* had always been on the backburner — so it was a natural step to pick *Equinox* up with more time and more energy at hand.

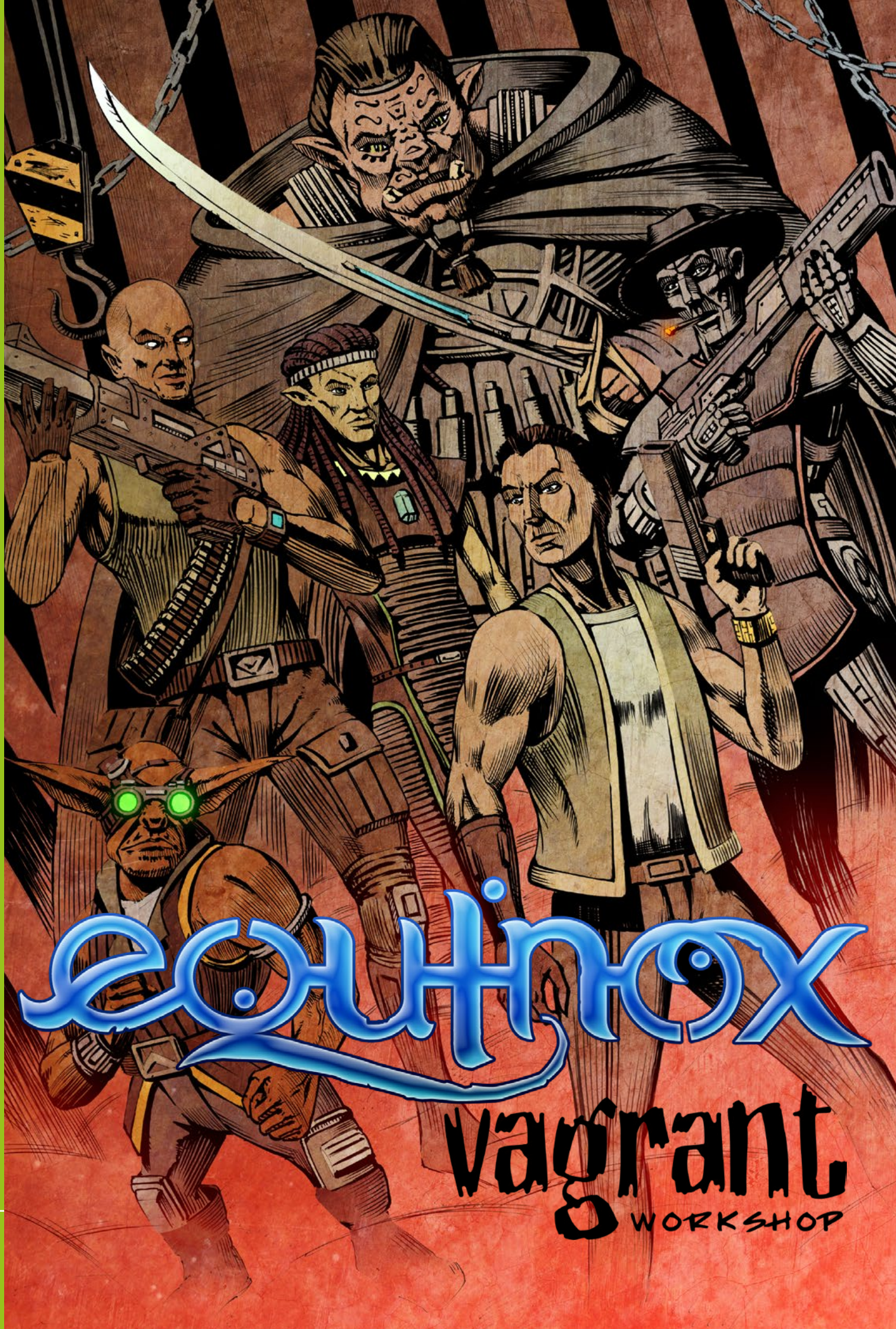
Equinox is a mix of sci-fi and western magic in space, with a special twist. The setting focuses on the war-ravaged and lawless Sol system and the shattered remains of Earth, now known as the Earth Belt. The characters are restless outcasts and misfits living on the fringe of galactic society. The basic setting considers them as rebels and pirates on space battles, fighting the forces of evil, and carving out a living on the edge of the universe. The characters in this future fantasy space opera game are larger than life, outcasts wielding mystic powers

and 'nethertech' relics, perfect Hollywood action heroes playing parts in a fantastic saga set in space in a faraway future.

Despite us steering in a pirate-focused direction initially, the setting combines a wide range of classic science fiction styles and ideas. Despite its inclusion of the fantastic and mystical, it provides rationales for many tropes of the genre. Many of the ideas we have incorporated in *Equinox* are quite common in science fiction, and draw from such famous movies and shows as *FarScape*, *Firefly/Serenity*, *Alien*, *Babylon 5*, *Titan AE*, *Deep Space Nine*, *Battlestar Galactica*, *Star Wars*, *Dune*, *Pitch Black/The Chronicles of Riddick*, and others. While the introduction of mystical energies takes the world into the fantastic, these energies obey strict 'scientific' rules and vary in power, depending on location. All this and more combines to make *Equinox* a world that is vibrant and tangible, a unique blend that sets it apart from other games out there.

The 'future mystical' setting seems to be becoming increasingly popular — with the likes of *Destiny* and *Warframe* trying to mix science fiction and fantasy elements. Would you place the setting of *Equinox* near these fictional universes, or any other games?





There have been quite a number of games trying this genre over the years, but none of them stuck or became mainstream. Starfinder is the latest (and probably largest) incarnation of such a thing. Equinox probably shares some roots with all of them, naturally.

The various games released by Vagrant Workshop and Pro Indie have very different systems and themes behind them. What's the reason for this? Are they each a response to a different inspiration, or perhaps aimed at different players?

Different authors and the desire to have a varied portfolio. Roleplaying games have great variety, not just in terms of setting and mechanics: theme, size, presentation, objectives — pen and paper is a vast and exotic gaming genre. We hope to capture some of that, and show that the genre's fringes can be just as exciting as the bigger lines out there.

What books, games or films most inspire you?

I am a junkie for TV series, but don't actually have a specific genre or theme that I prefer. To me it's all about how something is done and often, also, the history of how it came to be. I wanted to become a novel writer for a long time, but never really chased that goal. Instead, I have found that my knack is not to write down a single story in great detail, but rather to provide frameworks to bring a setting to life. I love creating such frameworks and the rules to make them tick, and then find out how people are using these to create individual stories.

What are you working on right now? What's next from Vagrant Workshop?

With Vagrant Workshop, we started to develop material via Patreon over the past two years. Right now, we have three books for Equinox coming out — two are direct results of the Patreon efforts, and one I wrote as a lead-in to that.

At the moment, I am focused on some German-language projects for our Pro Indie label. Our translation of *Itras By* won the German Roleplay Award for Best Rulebook of 2019, which provided us with motivation to pursue a couple of projects locally.

Congratulations! Do you prefer working in German or English? Do you find that the languages have different tastes when it comes to games, mechanics, and settings?

Yeah, I'd say there are strong cultural differences. I prefer working in the German language at the moment, but English was the one I started with.

What is the most challenging part of running a small indie games company?

The limited budget. We don't have the sales figures needed to have artists paint away our dreams, so getting quality artwork and making high quality products is always a challenge. However, we've always managed to overcome that hurdle and seem to be doing quite well.

If you could give a piece of advice to someone looking to self publish or start their own company to release their own roleplaying game, what would it be?

Never give up!

What is the last book you read?

That would be Ken Grimwood's *Replay*, although it was a re-read after many years. Imagine a more sincere version of *Groundhog Day*, playing out over lifetimes instead of a day. Highly recommended; it left me wondering how that story would turn out if it was adapted to modern times.

Do video games inspire your projects?

They certainly do, but I'm not playing as many video games as I would like to.

That's something we've heard before! What are your favourites?

I really enjoyed *Portal 2* and love *Grand Theft Auto V*. And I can't wait for *Cyberpunk 2077*.

It strikes us that Equinox would make an incredible setting for a video game. Would you consider going into video games?

If CD Projekt Red approached me, I certainly would! But I also dream of winning the lottery, so that's not going to happen. Out on our own, we wouldn't dare to make moves in that direction.

Which roleplaying games hold a special place in your heart?

Apart from the obvious, *Warhammer*, they would be *Cyberpunk* and *Star Wars D6*. These are the games I would play and run anytime without asking questions.

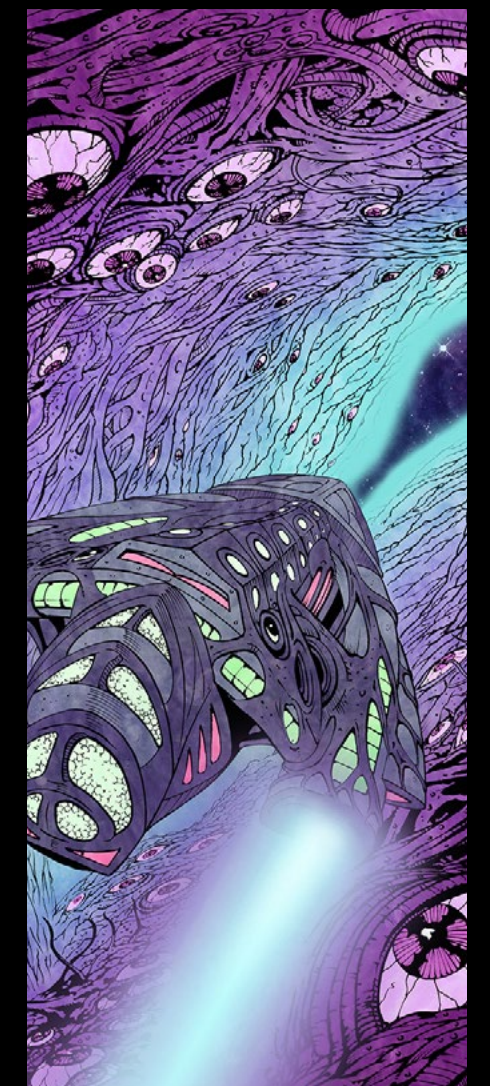
Player or games master?

I strongly prefer running games, especially after I found out that I am an ugly powergamer otherwise!

Describe your favourite character. It could be one you've had for years or one you've just started!

Well, I once had an invisible swordsman harassing the *Shadowrun* game of a dear friend for a while. Did I mention I was an ugly powergamer? I'm glad we are still friends after all these years!

Equinox, published by Vagrant Workshop, is available to download now. 📖



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WARGAMING

on a BUDGET



Wargames are a fantastically popular, but surprisingly expensive, hobby. However, if you're smart about it, there are ways to get started without breaking the bank.

So, you want to be a warlord. You've walked past small, crooked shops on bylanes and back-alleys, and seen the armies on display. Now you're seized by curiosity. How do they paint those tiny details? What rules decide life and death upon the tabletop? You want to know, more than anything. There's only one thing stopping you.

Money.

Unfortunately, wargaming is a perilously expensive hobby, especially with mainstream brands like Games Workshop. Model miniatures, or 'minis', can cost as much as £30 for a box of ten figures, which is barely enough to be considered a squad in some systems. This barrier to entry makes it fearsomely difficult for new players to enjoy the hobby if they're on a budget. So what's the best way to remedy this?

Enter the skirmish game.

For those not in the know, skirmish games are the smaller versions of the mighty wargame. They involve small warbands duking it out over single games, or a number of battles linked together to form a campaign. In essence, it's like *Dungeons & Dragons* without the roleplaying, and some extra tactical bits added on. Warbands are usually assembled around a theme. In fantasy skirmish games, which will be the example for this article, these warbands are often drawn from different nations such as dwarves, elves, or the undead.

A skirmish game allows you to craft a warband, and to think about who the individuals are who have come together and chosen to fight with one another. Perhaps they are a gathering group of undead, forced to work for a Necromancer who is learning their powers; or maybe a band of mercenaries thrown together during a series of wars.

This article will be broken down into steps, covering potential purchases from the ground up. The goal is to spend less than £70 for an entire skirmish force, paints and equipment. Do not underestimate the power of auction sites like eBay to find what you need! Let's see how we do.

“Skirmish games are the smaller versions of the mighty wargame.”

Step 1: the system

Before we start clipping sprues and thinning paints, we have to choose a skirmish system to play in. We want something that costs as little as possible, is easy to grok, and captures the themes and mechanics of the more popular systems and companies.

Lucky for us, one such system already exists. [Age of Fantasy: Skirmish](#) (AoFS) is a part of the beautifully-made *One Page Rules* family, which take IP-friendly versions of the grimdark future and fantasy realms and boil them down into neat one-page rulesets that are entirely free. You and your opponent just need to download the core rules as well as the army sheets for each of your warbands. Simple as that!

If you're looking for a different setting, the [Chain Reaction](#) version 3.1 rules are available online for free. There's also [5150](#) (to buy) and [No Limits](#) (also free).

Money spent so far: £0



Step 2: the models

Now we get to the tricky part. How do you obtain enough models for a decent warband without breaking the bank completely? Well, the best option would be some kind of deal where you get 20 or so models with a variety of equipment, poses, and styles for less than £1 per model.

If you're a bargain hunter, one way of doing that is to start browsing popular auction sites. Car boot sales are another great source of second-hand minis, as are 'bring and buy' sections at conventions like UK Games Expo (covered in Issue 1), Warfare in Reading, or Dragonmeet in London, both of which are this month. These days, the hobby of miniature wargaming is so popular that people are always looking to sell on their armies. Several of the team here at **Parallel Worlds** have developed their hobby collections by rescuing old models, often someone's neglected Christmas or birthday presents!

Another way of approaching this is to look at buying a board game to start off. Games like *Zombicide: Black Plague* have excellent character miniatures who might be the

starting point for your new project. After all, the characters in these games have to have a backstory, or maybe a few friends they hang out with in between adventures, right? Developing a warband around a board game might even lead you to start thinking up new rules for the game itself so you can include all your new models.

However, if you're going for a new boxed set range, the *Frostgrave* miniature kits from Wargames Factory are an excellent choice. While *Frostgrave* is itself a fantastic skirmish game, it lends itself to one specific setting. That, and the rulebook costs money, which could be better spent elsewhere by first-time players. For instance, if you wanted to build a human warband for *AoFS*, there are kits such as soldiers and barbarians to choose from. The female soldiers are particularly good, with the emphasis on realism. There are also cultists, Gnolls, undead, and more. Whilst the detail quality is not the highest, each kit contains a wealth of options such as alternate heads, weapon and shield arms, and even decorative bits like pouches and bandoliers! You can interchange these kits quite easily, too.

The 20 models in an £18 box will be enough to build a character to lead the warband, along with their loyal(ish) retinue of fellow warriors.

It's also worth taking a look at the rest of Wargames Factory's ranges. Most are produced for quite specific historical periods, like *Pike and Shotte*, but they have the advantage of being compatible in terms of size and shape. If you were going for a particular era or setting for your warband, say Napoleonic fantasy, this could be a place to start.

For a science fiction game, Wargames Factory used to produce a Shock Troops boxed set for the game *Alien Suns*. This gave you 20 soldiers in trench coats with gun options and all sorts of accessories too. These occasionally appear on eBay and other auction sites. However, for the purposes of our project, we're going to start with *Frostgrave*.

Money spent so far: £18

Step 3: tools

Making miniatures from a collection of sprue parts requires a few bits and pieces. To start with, you need to get the parts off of the sprue, which means craft snips and/or a sharp knife. You can do this with scissors, but you'll blunt them quickly. You can also try this with a little bit of brute force, but you'll probably break some of the smaller pieces. Trust me, we've all done it.

So we need a good craft knife. You can pick one up with interchangeable blades for about £4.99. Be careful with it and keep your blunted blades, as they can be really useful for modelling later on.

To be safe, we'll add a set of snips too. A pair of good ones cost £3.95. Make sure you get the right sort, as different crafts use different types.

“Car boot sales are a great source of second-hand miniatures.”

To put the models together you're going to need some glue. Superglue works best with this kind of model plastic, and any brand will do. Let's allocate £5.00 for that.

- Knife – £4.99
- Snips – £3.95
- Glue – £5.00

You may also want to pick up some kneadatite, or 'green stuff'. This is a special type of moulding putty that you can use to fill in gaps on a model. It comes in strips of yellow and blue, which you mix together in tiny amounts. It also comes in liquid form which you just paint on. Once it hardens overnight, it's as strong as the plastic and will be invisible once you paint it.

- Kneadatite – £2.69

Total spent on tools: £16.63

Money spent so far: £34.63



Step 4: the paint

Painting is a major part of the wargaming hobby, and can appear quite intimidating to newcomers — although others take it to it right from the start and become more enthused by that part of things than actually playing the games!

There are many, many online tutorials that aren't within the scope of this guide, but rest assured — painting your miniatures to a good standard is much easier than you'd think. Starting out, we don't need any Golden Demon award-winning levels of work; just something to give your little dudes some character and easily identify them on the battlefield.

Most painters of miniatures use acrylic-based paints because they are easy to work with. A bit of water cleans the brush, and you're ready for the next colour. The style of painting can vary. *Warhammer* miniatures

“Most painters of miniatures use acrylic-based paints because they are easy to work with.”

lend themselves to a sort of cartoonish treatment, but this has gradually become less obvious over the years.

There are a variety of ranges of acrylics you can try. The cheapest option is to go to an art shop or online art store and buy tubes of the stuff. Decanting these into some sealable tubs and mixing in a little water will give you the same consistency of paint

as Army Painter, Vallejo, Revell, or any of the other ranges available.

Now, you obviously can't finger-paint your models to achieve the look you want, so we'll need to get a couple of brushes. It terms of size, a '000' brush is good for detail and a cheap one should last long enough to work with 20 or so models. A '1' brush is good for bigger sections and undercoating.

A value pack of fine detail brushes is going to cost around £5, but you can certainly pay more for better quality here. Washing your brushes is important: once the hairs on the end start to separate, you'll be making life difficult for yourself.

Money spent so far: £39.63

However, this method of painting does require some patience. You'll be undercoating, then base colouring, then applying some washes, then dry-brushing to get a good 'look'.

There's a different approach: Games Workshop's new Contrast line of paints. They're essentially thicker washes and glazes mixed together, providing a superb level of highlighting and shading with a single application. For this example, we're going to outfit our human warband with some simple medieval schemes to give them a grounded, gritty look. This also has the advantage of making any first-time errors less visible!

Now, this method admittedly isn't the absolute cheapest possible, but it does have the advantage of being quick and getting our miniatures to the tabletop in time for the weekend. Given that we're starting out with a basecoat spray, we can get a production line going very quickly and after a few hours, we should have a good-looking warband.

The paints we'll use are:

- Wrathbone Spray, for the basecoat.
- Leadbelcher, for any weapons and metallic bits.
- Guilliman Flesh, for the skintones.

- Skeleton Horde, for the off-white cloth.
- Blood Angels Red, for the main cloth pieces.

Total on paints: £24.32

The cheaper alternative means spending a bit more time on paints. Here's the breakdown, mostly from [Battle Forge](#), but often more easily found on eBay:

- Generic Acrylic Black (on eBay, big tube) – £2.95
- Elf flesh Vallejo Game Colour – £3.00
- Chainmail Vallejo Game Colour – £3.00
- Additional colour — perhaps a brown for the pouches and belts? – £3.00
- Additional colour — something bright for the clothing? – £3.00

We'll get a small discount on buying a few colours from Battle Forge, so the total comes to £13.75. With the saving you might want to go for some more colours, but that's up to you. You can get the same kind of detail effects as the Games Workshop washes and shades by diluting your paints right down.

“Model miniatures can cost as much as £30 for a box of ten figures.”

As you can see, paints and tools can be a big price component here. But the cost is mitigated by how much use you'll get out of them. Whichever method you choose, there should be enough paint left over to manage a second warband or a few reinforcements. Of course, if you have a friend who's already into wargaming, it might be a good idea to borrow some of their stuff until you're absolutely sure you're hooked.

This guide assumes you'll be able to source dice from board games and such that you already own, because, to be frank, there's such a dizzying number of dice manufacturers it'd be impossible to weigh them up in one article.

Total money spent: £63.95 or £53.38, depending on which paint option you went with.

Where next?

So you want to know more? Excellent. From skirmish gaming, branching into wargaming proper is very simple. There are lots of mid-level wargames with larger armies you might want to try. For example, *Dragon Rampant* is an excellent wargame for mid-sized armies, and damned affordable to boot.

Alternatively, you might start to use your miniatures for a favourite board game or two, like *Gloomhaven*, whose creator, Isaac Childres, we interviewed in Issue 1. The monsters in *Gloomhaven* are on cardboard stands, so using your warband for cultists, bandits, city guards or mercenaries can really add something to the game.

You can even use your warband characters for a new roleplaying session, as player characters and non-player characters for an adventure.

The hobby of collecting, modelling, painting, and playing with wargaming miniatures has never been more popular or approachable than it is now. 🔥



Words:
Christopher Jarvis

Design:
Angus McNicholl

If there's a board game which is credited with jump-starting the modern board game phenomenon, it's *The Settlers of Catan* (now simply called *Catan*). This award-winning building game combined elements which were familiar to traditional board games — collecting cards and rolling dice — and combined it with a more free-form approach to making progress and choosing a winning strategy. Players roll two dice and collect resources based on the sum. It's a solid game and a modern classic. There's just one problem: it's far too easy to get to your turn and be unable to do anything.



Designer:
John D. Clair

Publisher:
AEG

RRP:
£38.99

Fast-forward a bunch of years and we have *Space Base*. It has a familiar play cycle of 'roll dice, collect resources, buy upgrades', but where it scores highly is that turns are fast and it is very nearly impossible to have your turn without being able to make some kind of progress.

Each player has a board with slots marked 1–12. This board is your base, and in each numbered slot is a spaceship which generates a certain type of income which, to begin with, is gold or 'influence' (a kind of minimum income per round). When you roll two six-sided dice, you can either collect the reward from the value of both (e.g. 11) or activate both slots for each individual die (e.g. 5 and 6). At the end of your turn, you may buy a new spaceship which replaces one of the ones in your base, gradually upgrading your income and points-generating powers.

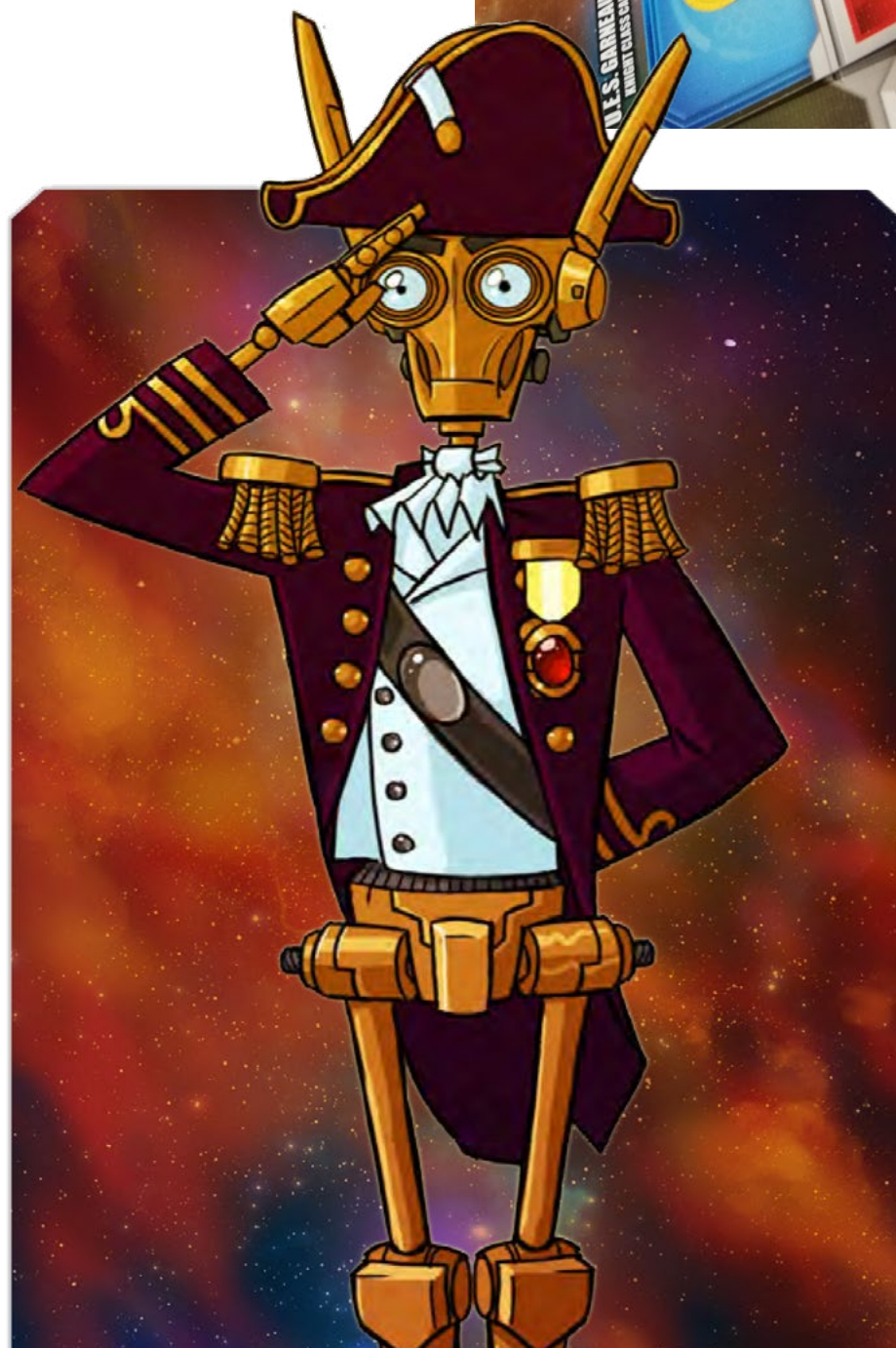
This is where the design gets clever — every ship in your base is designed to be 'retired'. Retired ships are flipped and placed under the board behind their number. Now, when that ship's number is rolled by *another* player, you also gain the resources from that card.

It's a genius twist on *Catan's* formula, which offers rewards for farming certain statistically-likely numbers, with the hope of a windfall as the dice travel around the other players as well as almost-guaranteed benefits on your own turns. Even if it gets to your turn to buy and you only have two gold, having rolled 'snake eyes' on your turn, there are still a large number of cards you can buy and, at the very least, this action pushes yet another card into the zone which generates income on other players' turns. In short, it's a game that never feels truly frustrating, because the direction of progress is always forward and victory is decided by who can accelerate their progress most efficiently.

The worst analogy I've ever used to describe this game is "it's like Bingo, but cool." And I stand by it. You can spend turn after turn carefully building up a cluster of upgrades around one number which hardly ever pops, but then suddenly someone rolls a 10 and you get 20 gold points, two influence and five victory points from a single activation. Having those amazing

“It is very nearly impossible to have your turn without being able to make some kind of progress.”

combos come off is a Bingo-like thrill, but with the satisfaction of having manipulated the numbers on your card throughout the game and made your own luck.



But what about the space theme, I hear you cry? It's a good question, and I'm sad to report that the theme is essentially paper-thin. *Space Base* could be about almost any other concept and the design would remain unchanged. It could be twelve plant pots side by side or twelve shop units on a high street. However, it does feature some beautiful isometric pixel art of a variety of imaginatively-designed space ships, many of which feature names very close to being a sci-fi reference, if you squint. This is not the amazing space fleet simulator you might be hoping for from the name and the cover art, but it is a very addictive game.

Space Base is a game for combo-builders. People who like to consider the value and statistical likelihood of a card being triggered and then carefully add it to a tableau of existing combos, hoping that those numbers will trigger an unstoppable sprint to the finish line. It's highly satisfying, with very little waiting between turns — even at the full player count of five — and each game takes less than an hour. Plus, there's enough variety in the card upgrades and possible combinations that it'll be a long time before you feel you've played the same game before.



“It's like Bingo, but cool.”

In short, don't expect a great space adventure, because it's not in this package. Do expect a beautifully produced, elegant and fast game of smooth progress, varied tools and satisfying engine-building. 🚀





Isharann Soulrender

The last of the celestial warriors fell, his empty armour collapsing to the mud-churned ground. Garillien watched as the warrior's body and spirit returned to the Heavens in a bolt of blinding light, its afterimage lingering behind his eyelids as he slumped against his talúnhook. He wouldn't be able to rest long. With the battle over, his work was only just beginning.

Sebell brushed against his leg, swimming around his knees, her serrated bill still bloody. Garillien absently stroked the rakerdart's abrasive scales while he focused on the pulsing currents of the aethersea around him. The tides were calming after their earlier tempest, and with their foes gone he could now sense the subtle drift of souls trickling from the fallen. With a gesture, Garillien intensified the glow of the lantern hanging from his helmet, drawing the lost souls to the lurelight.

Manipulation of the soul was a technique his people had perfected out of necessity rather than desire. A technique he had a certain talent with.

Straightening up, he strode to the surviving Namarti caste warriors, Sebell flitting away to explore some foliage. The pale, eyeless elves bowed their heads in acknowledgement as they collected the bodies of their comrades and separated the wounded from the dead. Garillien forced himself not to

look at the faces of the slain and dying Namarti. It would only make his task harder.

Instead, he calculated, weighing the six grievously-wounded Namarti against the souls stored in his lurelight. He bowed his head. It wouldn't be enough.

Frowning, he shot a glance across the battlefield to Persenoth. The leader of the raiding party was speaking with her Akhelian caste guards, their vicious eel steeds snapping and circling restlessly nearby. Based on her easy smile she was probably congratulating them on a resounding success.

Garillien turned away. He couldn't argue with her reasoning, not logically. The souls they would gather now that they could freely raid the fishing hamlet would recompense their losses, and then some. And those Namarti who had already passed beyond the veil could grant some of their brethren one final service, at least.

But... It shouldn't have been this way. Persenoth hadn't anticipated the presence of

the celestials, beings who could be defeated but never truly killed. Their souls were sacrosanct, impossible for the likes of Garillien to tear from their bodies. Even in defeat, the divine warriors could claim that victory.

He knelt beside the first of the wounded Namarti, laying down his talúnhook and placing a hand upon the eyeless elf's rune-marked forehead. Focusing his mind, he channelled the soul-essence from his lurelight into the shuddering Namarti. He let it flow through him, suffusing the pale elf's body, reknitting wounds and rejuvenating spirit alike. When the heavy iron collar around the Namarti's neck hummed with power, Garillien cut the link.

The Namarti sat up. Turning his eyeless face to Garillien, he nodded his thanks. Garillien took him by the shoulder and helped him to his feet, before moving to the next of the injured.

Their people were cursed, nearly all of their children born with shrivelled souls. Only through bolstering them with the souls of other sapient creatures could they hope

to survive beyond infancy. These were the Namarti. Those few lucky enough to be born with healthy souls became leaders, wizards, or priests. Garillien and Persenoth were both of this Isharann caste, tasked with securing the future of their people by any means.

Garillien stood, his lurelight dim and empty. Three wounded Namarti still lay before him, but he could not save them. By the time they had harvested enough souls from the inhabitants of the hamlet, it would be too late.

He cast a hand across them. A simple enchantment to lull them into a peaceful sleep. It was all he could do.

The other Namarti huddled together as Garillien retrieved his talúnhook and Sebell returned to his side. Some of them whispered thanks to him, while others stood in silence or embraced each other. There were no tears, for their lack of eyes made weeping impossible, but Garillien could feel the sorrow in their withered souls.

As he walked away, he wept for them.

I have always loved real-world sea creatures, as well as the tragic tales of elves in many fantasy settings. So when Games Workshop revealed their range of Idoneth Deepkin, elves coexisting in the ocean with fantastical fish and sea monsters, I had to pick up some of their models. The Isharann Soulrender particularly stood out to me due to his unique suit of armour, reminiscent of angler fish and sea urchins, and his pet fish who can assist him in battle! I used a variety of shades, washes, and metallic paints to give the armour an almost iridescent effect, and the tassels were given their vibrant coral colour with a red wash over a white basecoat.



Words:
Thomas Turnbull-
Ross

Design:
Angus McNicholl

ARROW VIDEO FRIGHTFEST[®] - TWENTY BLOODY YEARS -

The UK's foremost horror film festival is celebrating its 20th year. As they prepare for their Halloween event, we take a look at two decades of FrightFest...



The first time I went to FrightFest, I didn't think of myself as a horror fan. I liked vampires, and I would tell anyone who would sit still for it about the time I'd seen *The Woman in Black* on stage and then couldn't sleep until the sun came up, but I didn't know much about the genre as a whole. However, FrightFest was hosting the first UK screening of Timur Bekmambetov's *Day Watch* and I was desperate to see it, having fallen in love with its predecessor, *Night Watch*.

The film was preceded by a surprise short (*In the Walls*, a funny but genuinely unsettling story about a killer fetus) and a brief Q&A with its director. The atmosphere in the room was relaxed and eager; the audience both wanted to be pleased and were pretty sure they would be. At the end of *Day Watch's*

biggest action set piece, a gravity-defying motorcycle chase, the crowd spontaneously applauded — something I'd never experienced in a cinema before.

More than ten years later, I do call myself a horror fan — but I'm not sure I'd call *Day Watch* a horror movie. It's more of a hybrid, existing on the borders of action and thriller, fantasy and horror. As such, though, *Day Watch* fits in perfectly with what I now think of as a quintessential FrightFest experience. My first time out, I got all the hallmarks of the festival: a UK premiere; some surprise bonus content; interaction with creators; and a film which, while crowd-pleasing, illustrates how broad and permeable the boundaries of the horror genre are.

“The crowd spontaneously applauded — something I'd never experienced in a cinema before.”

What is FrightFest?

FrightFest is the UK's biggest horror film festival. It first ran for four days over the August bank holiday weekend of the year 2000, hosted by the Prince Charles Cinema. The festival was organised by the team who continue to run it today: film producer Paul McEvoy, distributor Ian Rattray, and journalist Alan Jones (publicist Greg Day joined as a co-director in 2006). Jones had previously run the Scala Cinema's 'Shock Around the Clock' festival in the 80s, and later programmed a horror season for the British Film Institute called 'Fantasm' — an event he afterwards considered mismatched to the 'rarefied' atmosphere of the National Film Theatre.



FrightFest was to be a more ambitious undertaking than either of these; the intention was to create a horror fantasy festival which could compete with the likes of [Sitges](#) or the comprehensively-named [Brussels International Fantasy Fantastic Thriller and Science Fiction Film Festival](#).

It quickly became clear that there was a UK market to meet this ambition. To accommodate increasing demand for tickets, the festival moved to the Odeon Leicester Square in 2005, and then to the UK's largest cinema screen at the Empire Cinema in 2009. Following some last-minute additional screenings in preceding years, the festival's running time officially increased from four days to five in 2007. Today, FrightFest takes place across six screens in Cineworld Leicester Square and its original home the Prince Charles Cinema, with one main screen line-up and three competing 'discovery' screens. It features more than 70 films in addition to interviews, previews and short film showcases. The FrightFest umbrella now also includes FrightFest Glasgow, a three day event in March, the single day FrightFest Halloween, and FrightFest Presents, a distribution label.



Words:
Jane Clewett

Design:
Yana Koleva



What makes a FrightFest film?

The only thing all FrightFest films have in common is that they've been watched (and presumably liked) by one of the festival's directors. English-language films predominate, but a typical five day line-up will include one or two films in other languages even if you never venture beyond the main screen. Most of the films will be new, but a couple will be genre classics — of either the beloved or the forgotten variety. A few major upcoming releases are featured, but they're outnumbered by smaller, more independent films looking forward to much more limited distribution. For some, their screenings at FrightFest will be the only time they see the inside of a UK cinema.

Most interestingly, the festival's organisers interpret their 'fantasy horror' remit very broadly. They certainly don't shy away from slashers, monsters, ultraviolence, or the latest instalments of horror franchises like *Chucky* or *Puppetmaster*.

“For some, their screenings at FrightFest will be the only time they see the inside of a UK cinema.”



On the other hand, they're equally happy to feature movies that break away from the horror mould.

This year's festival closed with crime drama *A Good Woman Is Hard To Find* — a wonderfully tense, oppressive film, but one that could only possibly be called horror because of the extremes of violence the protagonist is forced to in the third act. Previous offerings have included *They Call Me Jeeg*, an Italian deconstruction of superhero tropes, *Anna and the Apocalypse*, the self-styled 'zombie Christmas musical', and Steve Oram's frankly unclassifiable *Aaaaaaaah!*, a story about a modern society with the mores of cavemen. The discovery screen line-ups have also featured a number of documentaries about horror films, filmmakers, and fans, including the charming *Best Worst Movie* (about the cast and fans of *Troll 2*) and last year's very funny *King Cohen: The Wild World of Filmmaker Larry Cohen*.

Should you go to FrightFest?

There are three levels of FrightFest tickets: single films, day passes, and weekend passes, covering the whole five days of the festival. Pass holders are automatically entitled to see every film on the main screen; they can also enter a lottery to see films they're interested in on the discovery screens. The festival isn't cheap, but it's not outrageously expensive; the £15 price for single tickets is roughly on a par with the £10-20 an individual ticket at the London Film Festival costs.

Whether the festival is worth it to you depends very much on your tastes. Despite my own positive early experience, I wouldn't recommend FrightFest to non-horror fans, or even to people who feel unsure about the genre. There are plenty of individual films that might appeal to fans of crime, thrillers, genre pastiches, or fantasy, but the festival as a whole assumes that you like horror, and you're likely to see some fairly graphic violence and splatter in trailers, advertising, and even the festival idents. In addition, there's never a guarantee that the film on the schedule is the only thing you're going to see — any showing might also include a surprise short film, television pilot, or sneak preview of an upcoming movie. These can be a wonderful bonus for fans! But for people planning to see something just within the levels of their tolerance they could be an unwelcome addition. If you don't like gore it's also worth noting that FrightFest screenings tend to be uncut versions of the film in question; even if you know a film is going to be released in the UK as a 15, the version you watch at FrightFest could well have 18-rated content.

“Any showing might also include a surprise short film, television pilot, or sneak preview of an upcoming movie.”



As mentioned above, FrightFest's programming is broad and eclectic. A typical day's line-up might include something genuinely scary, something that leans more towards comedy, something that clings tightly to genre

tropes, and something that you barely register as horror at all. It would be pretty unusual to see two films from the same subgenre on the same day unless you actively went looking for them. If you are generally picky about your horror, FrightFest may not be the festival for you.

For me, though, FrightFest's eclecticism is its greatest strength. It's a unique and joyous experience to settle down for a full day of movies having almost no idea what you're going to get, and be swept along for the ride. The festival's focus on smaller productions also means that FrightFest gives you the chance to see films you mightn't otherwise see in a cinema — or possibly at all! Some of my favourite films of the last decade have been my 'film of the festival' at FrightFest, and later went straight to streaming services, where I would never have known I ought to look for them. The festival's other big draw is its friendly atmosphere; clap for the films you enjoyed, chat to their creators and the festival organisers, and introduce yourself to your fellow attendees — they'll generally be very happy to talk to you.

FrightFest is not for everyone. It's not even for every horror fan. But bring an open mind and a strong stomach, and you just might have the time of your life.

Words:
Allen Stroud

Design:
Steve Cooksey

HOMEWORLD

“

Alex Garden had been looking to emulate the cinematic space opera qualities of *Star Wars*, centered around a *Battlestar Galactica*-like story premise.

”

The Mothership is standing by

Homeworld, produced by Relic Entertainment, first appeared in 1999. At that point, the real-time strategy (RTS) genre, with its resource management, manufacturing, and large-scale battles, had been around since 1992, with the first release of *Dune*. *Warcraft: Orc versus Humans*, *Dune II*, and then *Command and Conquer* in 1995 refined the formula. *Age of Empires*, released in 1997, took the same base building mechanics into a quasi historical/fantasy setting, and *Total Annihilation* (also in 1997) introduced self-replicating robots and a science fiction setting. It was only logical that another games company would make a similar leap and set a game in space itself.

He seems incapable of three-dimensional thinking

At first glance, the change of setting is the most notable alteration, and magazine reviews at the time focused on the 'space opera' visuals and fleet-management qualities of the experience. In this first incarnation, the Mothership — the iconic image of the franchise box art — was one of two options for the player, but in both versions acted as a mobile production centre, which was a change from the traditional fixed camp requirement of the RTS genre. Another innovation was the three-dimensional area of deployment, a marked departure from the two-dimensional terrestrial theatres of war players were used to. Judging by the reviews, it seemed clear with hindsight that certain scenario snippets had been all that eager reviewers had been able to experience. However, they didn't tell the whole story of the game that was to come.

With the announcement of an upcoming release in one of PC gaming's most loved franchises, we go back to the start to find out what it is that makes *Homeworld* so magical.

In PC games, what we identify as a classic can be ephemeral. There are many elements that go into the design and production of a game, and many subjective factors that can influence our view of the experience playing it. We don't just watch games, we participate in them; and that participation should allow us to shape what happens. The best games make us feel like we have affected their outcome and connect with the circumstances and role we've taken on in the game's fictional premise.

Kharak is burning

What made *Homeworld* memorable was the emphasis on story and cinematic visuals. Relic co-founder Alex Garden had been looking to emulate the cinematic space opera qualities of *Star Wars*, centered around a *Battlestar Galactica*-like story premise. The tragic beginning, with the Mothership fleeing a destroyed world carrying its last cryogenically frozen survivors in its cargo hold, was set up with a series of cut scenes and tutorial scenarios that blended seamlessly into the beginning of the story. The choice of Samuel Barber's bittersweet *Adagio for Strings* as the soundtrack for these moments, along with the initial activation of the Mothership beforehand, perfectly set up a complex series of epic narrative escalations. The Kushan people had launched their first hyperspace-capable colonial ship and successfully tested its new engines. Yet, at the very moment of triumph, their planet had been destroyed.

The player is intrinsically involved in this tragedy. The Mothership is called away whilst the attack happens, and returns just in time to save the colonist survivors. The series of missions are carefully structured

to increase in difficulty, putting the player in a dangerous, unstable position and cutting away the initial equilibrium of the game's premise. This helps on two fronts. In terms of the narrative, it plays close to the *Battlestar Galactica* theme: the journey of a rag-tag fleet. In terms of game reward, it lowers expectations. Survival becomes the achievement, rather than victory and spoils.

One aspect of play in the first *Homeworld* game that was initially underestimated was the use of salvage corvettes to capture enemy ships. The game contains an array of different neutral and enemy craft as well as the developing Kushan fleet, unlocked with research and development. The salvage options helped a player gain new ships before some of that research became available and, with the variety of designs, gave their fleet more of a motley appearance.

Gradually the Kushan exiles follow the path laid out for them and discover their original homeworld, Hliigara, lost for generations after a galactic war. The scenarios escalate into a riotous space battle, full of resource management and glorious visuals.

“I’d go to bed imagining the lives of the people on board the Mothership, desperately fighting to survive in a hostile galaxy.”

Fans

Homeworld drew an eager audience of gamers from a variety of different places. The ‘4X’ (eXplore, eXpand, eXploit, and eXterminate) genre tended to be turn-based, unlike *Homeworld*, but there were a lot of science fiction games which had similar visual aesthetics. RTS players found a home with most of the familiar gameplay mechanics and as more casual gamers discovered it and saw its beautiful graphics they took it to their hearts as well.

I bought my first proper PC as a university student in 1996. I missed out on *Dune*, but caught up with *Command and Conquer* and *Age of Empires*. When *Homeworld* came along, I was in my graduate year and played it ceaselessly. The slower resource acquisition elements were a familiar experience, and I loved zooming in and out on my spaceships. At the time, the visuals were some of the best you could find, and

resonated with the science fiction novels I was reading at the time. I’d go to bed imagining the lives of the people on board the Mothership, desperately fighting to survive in a hostile galaxy.

Any child of the eighties who read Eagle comics and knows the work of Ian Kennedy can see something of his work in the artistic design of *Homeworld*; the elegant lines mixed with utilitarian details are something both visions share, and something Hello Games must have drawn a little inspiration from when they began developing *No Man’s Sky* (2016).

Homeworld Cataclysm and *Homeworld 2*

The popularity of the franchise saw a clamour for sequels. *Homeworld: Cataclysm* came out in 2000: a spin-off sequel focusing on the adventures of Kith Somtaaw, one of the clans that had survived the journey to Hliigara. The spacecraft roster didn’t include the iconic Mothership, but did introduce some new gameplay features, such as a game speed toggle and an innovative enemy in the shape of The Beast, who infected ships and became a fascinating player choice in the multi-player game.

Homeworld 2 followed in 2003, with a return to the main story. Hliigara is attacked by a new threat, forcing a temporary evacuation and the reactivation of the Mothership. The gameplay of the sequel is probably the best and most complete, but the story doesn’t have the same resonance as the original. In any story, it is difficult to play the same trick twice; and whilst the single-player campaign has its strengths, *Homeworld 2* was certainly a game I played more as a multiplayer treat with my relatives and friends than for its story.



Homeworld Remastered

In 2004, Relic Entertainment was bought by THQ. The new owner immediately turned their attention to *Dawn of War* — a licensed series of RTS games that made use of Games Workshop's Warhammer 40,000 fictional universe. The Homeworld franchise remained largely neglected with some confusion over who, between Sierra Entertainment and Relic, owned the rights to the brand.

In April 2013 THQ filed for bankruptcy and the Homeworld rights were sold to Gearbox Software. Immediately, in partnership with a company of former *Homeworld* designers called Blackbird Interactive, Gearbox announced their intention to publish a package of the two titles *Homeworld* and *Homeworld 2*, with upgraded graphics, sound, and a complete engine overhaul. It was released as the *Homeworld: Remastered Collection*.

In many ways, this update was a triumph for the underlying gameplay design of the original games. Both stood up well against modern RTS games but lacked the ability to take advantage of modern graphics cards, so the visual aesthetic of the past had become a nostalgic disappointment to faithful fans of the franchise. A remastered game was the ultimate tribute to the players who had kept the faith, hoping that the series would not be consigned into oblivion.

Homeworld: Remastered Collection was released in 2015, closely followed by a prequel. 2016's *Homeworld: Deserts of Kharak* returned the franchise to its inspirational roots, set as a modern ground-based RTS more reminiscent of *Dune*.

Deserts of Kharak was perhaps the most exciting expansion of the Homeworld

mythos since the original game. The decision to focus on the society of Kharak, in decay owing to the changing climate, allowed for a focus on the conflict between the 'kiith' (or clans) of the Kushian civilisation. The mysterious backstory of the first game was greatly enriched by the plot of the new game, setting up a variety of possible continuing narratives.

In fact, back in 2016, this writer was in direct negotiations with Gearbox software to write a novel set in Kharak society. The premise was to follow up from the end of *Deserts of Kharak* and move the story forward towards the starting point of *Homeworld* (1999) with the mysterious attack that wiped out the planet. Could there have been a betrayal of the Kushians by some of their own people? I still have hopes to work on this franchise one day, as the lore is so rich and interesting.

“Survival becomes the achievement, rather than victory and spoils.”

Homeworld 3

In August 2019, Gearbox Software and Blackbird Interactive announced that they have started work on *Homeworld 3*, planned for release in 2022. As part of this development they have launched an unusual crowdfunding campaign on Fig. Apparently, the game is already fully funded; the crowdfunding campaign is in fact an opportunity for fans of the franchise to invest in the game. Fig has a system of investment and return which sees backers choose a monetary profit for their initial stake (minimum \$500 in this case) rather than a series of rewards, and it is this option that Gearbox and Blackbird appear to be focusing on (although there are a series of reward tiers for people who prefer to simply back the game). The usual set of social media adverts have also begun to appear, appealing particularly to fans of the franchise.

The trailer for *Homeworld 3* picks up the story at the end of *Homeworld 2*. The hyperspace gates have opened, and now is the time to explore. The visuals are reminiscent of the past games, with enough of a rework to get the best out of modern computers. The music score invokes much of the recent *Deserts of Kharak*, with a slight twist towards a *Blade Runner* aesthetic.

Homeworld stands

With a twenty-year legacy, the Homeworld franchise has outlasted many of the other fictions it drew inspiration from. *Battlestar Galactica* came and went in the time Homeworld was locked away in licensing hell; *Dune* will be returning to the cinemas in 2020. *Warcraft* evolved into an MMO and *Command and Conquer* has become a mobile platform game (although Electronic Arts has indicated it will revisit the older games sometime in the near future). *Total Annihilation* was reborn as *Supreme Commander* in 2007, with a highly-regarded standalone expansion shortly afterwards, but has gone dark since then. The only other iconic game of the RTS period, *Age of Empires*, has recently followed a similar route to Homeworld, with a definitive remastered edition of the old games released in 2018.

Of course, *Star Wars* remains out there; and, through a multitude of games and films, continues to feed adults and children their special diet of Spitfires in space. This is where Homeworld stands: a little to the left and behind the vast Disney brand, but always ready and waiting to cater to the imaginations of eager science fiction fans and gamers who want to command a space fleet on a lonely journey — out there, into the black. 🌌



THE SUCCESS OF SIMPLICITY IN MODERN GAMING

Terraria is a 2D side-scrolling sandbox game that released way back in 2011. It is still going strong today, with more updates to come. How can it compete in the modern gaming world of photo-realistic graphics?

Ask a gamer what never changes, and there's a few answers you might get. 'War', 'FIFA', 'EA', or perhaps 'Bethesda's persistence in releasing new versions of *Skyrim*'. I would add another entry: *Terraria's* price on Steam.

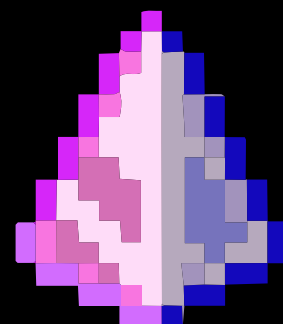
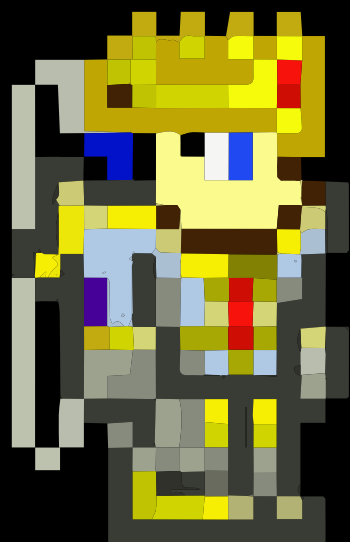
Ok, Steam has sales all the time. Aside from those, and one rise in its base price in 2014, *Terraria* has maintained a steady price of £6.99 with impressive consistency. Sure, it's not a high price – but for a title to maintain a price tag higher than at its release for so many years is a little anomalous.

“Each update brought more to what fans believed was already a near-perfect game.”

Even more unusually, *Terraria* was born right in the era of, for lack of a better term, 'disposable gaming'. With new 'AAA' titles being pumped out yearly by the massive studios, a 2D side-scroller from

an indie developer could easily have been overlooked. Yet, many years (and many iterations of *Call of Duty*) later, *Terraria* had clocked over 27 million sales.

All very impressive – but how? The past decade of gaming has demonstrated great technological leaps, to the point where screenshots can be indistinguishable from photographs. Yet a pixelated side-scroller where you battle floating eyeballs still grips a large audience.



Words:
Richard Watson
Design:
Angus McNicholl



Who needs 3D anyway?

So far, there have been four major stages of *Terraria*'s development. From the initial release, 1.0, to the current 1.3, each large patch has added a lot of content. With new bosses, events, weaponry, armour, accessories, and mechanics, the game has well over doubled in size.

Each update brought more to what fans believed was already a near-perfect game. 1.1 brought 'hardmode', an entirely new section of the game tacked onto the end, albeit a little haphazardly. 1.2 added over 1,000 new items, as well as a multitude of bosses and events, as well as UI and 'quality of life' improvements.

Most recently, 1.3 introduced a final boss, and entire new difficulty: 'expert mode'. For many players who had mastered defeating any boss on the first night (and in many cases sticking it on YouTube), expert mode introduced a sharp difficulty increase proving popular in today's *Dark Souls*-hardened pseudo-masochistic gaming community.

“
Combat is very much the
game's central element.”

Terraria's story is not over yet, either; the upcoming update 1.4, known as 'Journey's End', is to be the final entry in the game's journal (well, at least until *Terraria 2*). Judging by the spoilers and teasers revealed so far, 'Journey's End' will add new boss content, graphical changes, and an even more gruelling level of difficulty: 'master mode'.

Re-logic have clearly put a great deal of love and care into the game. While supporting a game for so long isn't unheard of, it is a great deal more unusual for one that isn't massively multiplayer. This doesn't explain the game's success, though; if it wasn't so popular, the updates wouldn't have come.

In trying to unravel the mystery, I went back to play it again. I'd wanted to wait for 1.4 to drop, but with such a foggy development timeline — and my deadline for this article rapidly approaching — I caved in early. It had been a year since I last played, yet I instantly felt gripped.

I dived straight into expert mode, and after a few nights of helpless slaughter (I'm not going to disclose who was slaughtering whom), I found myself entering hardmode. After some more nights of slaughter, some dead mechanical bosses, and some less-than-PG language directed at a giant carnivorous plant, I had completely forgotten what I was meant to be doing.

Though it may sound a little clichéd, in the moment I remembered why I was playing, it clicked. For the umpteenth time, *Terraria* had roped me in. Hours and days melted away as I farmed a winged pig-shark Cthulunado-launching (yes, really) thing and constructed my glorious new mage tower.

“
The kill feels that much
more rewarding when
your gear was pulled out
of the ground with your
own bloodied hands.”

The game's simplicity is the key to its success. A mere seven pounds unlocks a 2D world of adventure, underground jungles, giant glowing mushrooms, and magically-levitating skulls. And it's your world: aside from boss and gear progression, there are no rails you have to follow. The guide will give you hints as to what milestone is next, but your route of progression is up to you.

“
You can be sure that if
you die, it's your fault.”

The player is given the choice of magic, guns, bows and arrows, minions, or just a good old sword. Combat is very much the game's central element; each boss has unique mechanics to stretch and challenge the player. Weapon turnover is constant, with one individual weapon rarely being useful for more than a couple of bosses.

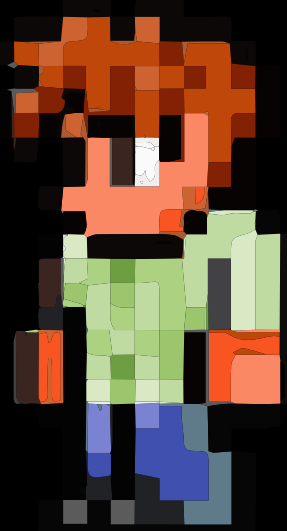
It feels rewarding because it makes you work for your achievements; but it doesn't take anything away unfairly, either. You can be sure that if you die, it's your fault. Every time. The more you die, the more you learn, and the angrier you get. Bosses can take dozens of rage-filled attempts, but you find yourself repeatedly coming back.

Sound familiar? The appeal of a challenge never fails to hook a gamer. You almost forget it's a 2D side-scroller when you're trying to avoid dying at the jaws of a giant laser-shooting mechanical worm for the tenth time. All you care about is surviving, and the well-earned kill feels that much more rewarding when your gear was pulled out of the ground with your own bloodied hands.

Even approaching a decade since original release, *Terraria* is still there for me whenever I burn out on whatever other game previously caught my fancy. While I'm

a little ashamed to admit it, as of writing I've clocked just shy of 1,400 hours in its two-dimensional world. Ironically, its low price has led me to spend more, in that I've bought probably six or seven copies for friends who have subsequently become addicted, too.

If we widen our scope, it's clear *Terraria* isn't alone. With games like *Dead Cells*, *Stardew Valley*, and *Starbound*, it's evident that a game can still succeed on a handful of pixels. 🍌



DIAMONDS IN THE ROUGH:

ADVENTUROUS!
READ

What's changed in the 21st Century?

The ebook took off in 2007, with early adopters quickly claiming a potentially-lucrative market share and audience. Opportunistic authors got in ahead of the established publishing houses. That year, the Kindle was the great new piece of technology to own, but a lot of the content available in book stores wasn't available on the new platform. So, readers turned to whatever they could find. Some of it was cheap, some of it was free, and a lot of it wasn't very good.

Now, twelve years later,

the landscape has changed. The ebook revolution — which seemed like it might signal the end of print — has peaked and levelled off. Sales are broadly even between paperbacks and ebooks. The market for dedicated devices has fallen, with most people using phones, tablets, and laptops to read whatever they want to read in PDF, epub, and Mobi formats.

In 2019, anyone with some knowledge of Amazon's Kindle Direct website can set up a book to be published. In fact, anyone who learned how to write a website in the 90s

can make an ebook. The basic language used is HTML, so there isn't much to learn if you can remember how you used to put your dot coms together.

Generally, ebooks can't handle complex design, which is why they've not managed to establish themselves as a rival to PDFs or other electronic comic book formats. But they work well as a cheaper option, particularly for voracious readers and researchers who need to get a quick copy of something for an essay or class.

In the publishing industry, the bigger publishers have lower costs on physical books than smaller publishers. This is because their print runs are huge, so the cost per copy goes down. But ebooks are an area where smaller independent publishers and self-published authors can compete.

The science fiction, horror, and fantasy publishing industry in the United Kingdom is thriving. The big imprints (publishing labels owned by larger publishing houses, usually genre-specific) are usually the ones you see in Waterstones, Foyles, or Blackwells, but occasionally you'll find a smaller press getting its books on their shelves. Other genres really cannot compare in terms of the sheer number of titles and demand at all levels. Internationally-recognised authors are now commonly published by a variety of sources — in the past, that didn't happen.

Self-published books — how can you tell if you'll enjoy one?

These days, finding a good book to read can be tricky. Not because there aren't enough books around; the science fiction, fantasy, and horror markets are absolutely saturated, so navigating through the flood to get to something you'll enjoy can be difficult.

Some readers stick to the authors and series they know. That way, there's a bit of a guarantee of the kind of story you're going to get. However, it also means a lot of great stuff may be passing you by.

This article is written for readers who are looking to be a little bit more adventurous and try something new. If that's you, brilliant. There are hundreds of fantastic writers out there who really need your support. Every writer's path to finding their readers is a different one and if you're prepared to take a risk on a new

book it can be a good experience for both of you — even if you don't like it. Trying something different stretches us and makes us aware of the good and the bad in every story we've read.

Here at **Parallel Worlds**, we want to find some diamonds — and we know there's a few out there. Hopefully we can encourage you to start looking too, and find more great writers of science fiction, fantasy, and horror who really deserve a bigger audience.

“Internationally-renowned authors self-publish occasionally.”

Words:
Allen Stroud

Design:
Angus McNicholl

Art:
**MinDof,
manuta**



Many smaller publishing companies are basically individual authors who have become frustrated with the high levels of rejection at the top of the industry. Most businesses like Gollancz, Harper Voyager, Penguin, and their ilk only accept 'agented' submissions, and most agents reject around 90% of what they are sent. So aiming high is all very well, but it isn't necessarily a mark of how good a book is — just a measure of what has caught a particular agent's eye.

Some independent publishers have gained a reputation for excellent work. Newcon Press (featured in Issue 2), who publish Adrian Tchaikovsky, have been nominated for many industry awards over the years, as have imprints like Fox Spirit, Luna Press, PS Publishing, and others. Similarly, Angry Robot, Titan Books and Rebellion are diverse organisations with different products, like comics, within the same business.

Finding novels produced by some of these companies can require you knowing where to look. Most will be at the conventions, like Worldcon, Eastercon, and Fantasycon. Forbidden Planet in London are owned by Titan Books and stock many rare titles, as do little independent bookshops like Books on the Hill in Clevedon.

“The ebook revolution — which seemed like it might signal the end of print — has peaked and levelled off.”

However, sometimes a book needs to be self-published. The stigma attached to this, and most of the vanity publishing industry that catered for it in the last millennium, has mostly vanished. In fact, internationally-renowned authors self-publish occasionally. There are moments where that is simply the best choice for the story and the writer. It does mean that percentages aren't going to other people, but it also means the writer is responsible for all aspects of getting the book to the reader. That means not only writing, but also editing, layout, cover, format, and distribution.

So — you're looking for a book to read and you want to support a new writer, or try something a little different? Ok. Here are a few things to look for:

Reviews. Read up on the book. See if other people enjoyed it. People are generally polite about books, even on the internet, but there are a few pointers you can always pick up from a review or two. Similarly, if you choose the book and read it, leave a review. You'd be surprised how much it means to an author's profile if you do. Amazon is the go-to place for reviews, but it's also good to look around and see what other websites are saying. (Ant Jones and I both review for SFbook (www.sfbook.com) which is a comprehensive reviewing website. We do try to squeeze in as many requests as we can.)

Cover design. There are plenty of pretty ebook covers that are a massive disappointment when you get to the text. However, a bit of effort put into the cover can give you a clear idea of what value the author placed in getting it organised. Some of the best books I own have plain and simple covers. Things that look hastily thrown together are what you might want to avoid.

Blurbs. It sounds obvious, but a back-page blurb sells the book. Writers are often really bad at writing these, or indeed at pitching their own work (trust me, I know!), but there can be some alerts that would put you off of a self-published ebook. Given that the writer can change their blurb on Amazon pretty easily, you'd think they should get the spelling and grammar right, wouldn't you?

Price. Most authors don't know the worth of their work, and many ebooks are inexpensive or free. If an author has written a 100,000-word novel, that will have taken them at least fifty days (if you're Stephen King) to write and then at least the same to edit, proof, format, and so on. Selling a book at a low price or giving it away for free can be a good idea, particularly if you have written a series, but it's still shorting the value of your work. Unfortunately, with so many books available for free, it does make it difficult for a writer not to be tempted to try a giveaway one or two to see if they translate into more sales. So, 'free' doesn't necessarily mean 'bad'.

With an independent publisher, things are a bit different. Most have a very good idea of the value of what they've taken on, in terms of time invested, contracts, current sales, and comparable sales with other novels or collections. Most will prefer you to be buying books from their website — that way, a higher percentage goes to the writer and the publisher and less to Amazon or another distributor.

Lastly, read the preview. Most books on Amazon have a preview option now, so you can get a feel for whether you'll like the writing style.

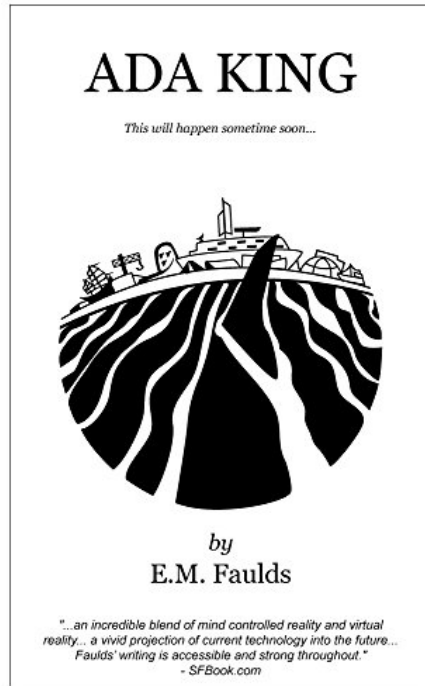
“Given that the writer can change their blurb on Amazon pretty easily, you'd think they should get the spelling and grammar right, wouldn't you?”

Some diamonds we've found

Here are a few examples of diamonds we've found that really deserve a bigger readership:

Ada King

by E. M. Faulds



The understated cover might make you overlook this little gem. *Ada King* is the story of a rebellious 'counter culture' society that springs up in the near future of our world. It blends together virtual reality and reality, as one extremely gifted individual seeks to forge an independent path, founding Raft City for people who have rejected the dominant dystopian societies that seek to oppress and exploit them. This is a fantastically-written thrill ride from start to finish, that is crammed with big ideas.

The Fractured Empire series

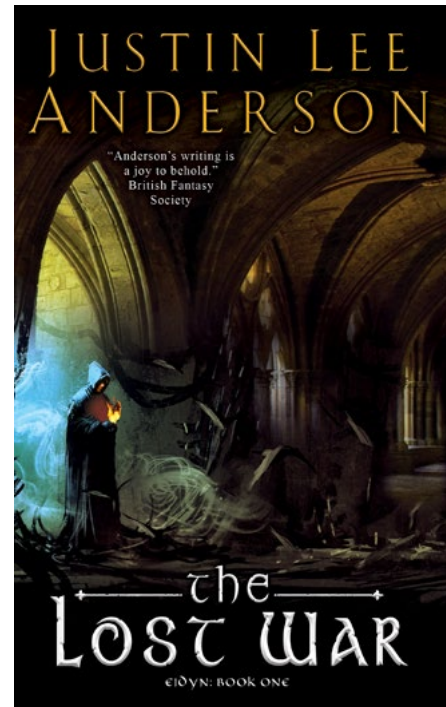
by Amy DuBoff



A space opera setting with telepathic agents and a 'secret interdimensional war'. DuBoff began her series in 2015. In four years, she's produced seven novels, been Nebula Award-nominated, and found time to write a variety of other science fiction in collaboration with other authors. This is the kind of accessible, epic science fiction you can devour. It's a total escape, with excellent writing throughout. There's also no sign of DuBoff slowing down any time soon: she's developing a collection of collaborations set in her fictional universe.

The Lost War

by Justin Lee Anderson



An epic fantasy, published by King Lot Publishing, which is actually Anderson's own imprint. This is a 500-page doorstop of a book. *The Lost War* has a bit of a clichéd opening, with a tavern fight and a rescue, but from then on it finds its feet, and is reminiscent of the classic 80s and 90s fantasy quests (by the likes of Brooks, Feist, and Gemmell) that some of us remember growing up with. The story is innovative and interesting, the characters have some depth, and the writer is certainly punching above his weight in the market. This book deserves a good audience amongst 'sword and sorcery' fans.

Becoming David

by Phil Sloman



Published by Hersham Horror, *Becoming David* is a novella-length story set in contemporary times that serves up a meticulous serial killer outwitted by a little dose of the supernatural.

Sloman's writing is very good. One or two choices prevent this being as scary as it might be, but the sense of disturbed, lingering awfulness continues all the way to the end. You really get a sense of the different characters in this work, each of them playing a part as it works its way towards a bittersweet conclusion.

Mr Sucky

by Duncan P. Bradshaw

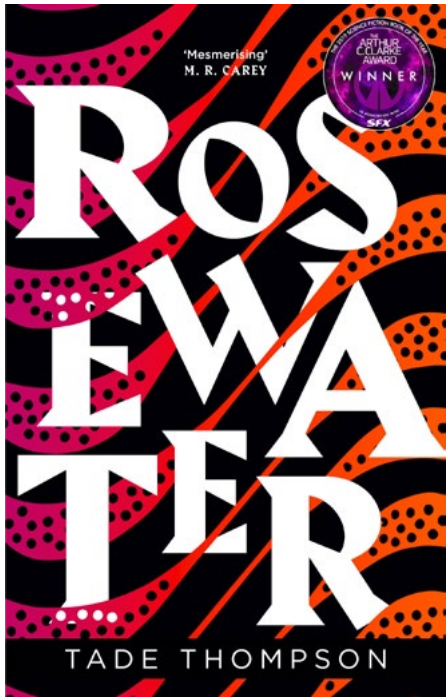


At first glance, this is the kind of book that can't really find a home with a major publisher unless someone's prepared to take a significant leap. *Mr Sucky* is available as an ebook or a paperback, but really you should buy the paperback as it looks like a faded vacuum cleaner instruction manual!

Inside, and past the assembly instructions and translated sections, you'll find a sharp comedy horror story told over nineteen chapters. The dialogue is fabulous, and the clever little touches in terms of visual design throughout are a delight to find. This is the kind of book your friends will be surprised to come across, and surprised they remember years later.

Over to you

So, there we have it: a few tips and recommendations from us, but the journey is far from over. If this article encourages you to try a new author or two, please do let us know – allen@parallelworlds.uk. Together, we can start talking about some great new stories and helping get them to readers who are prepared to be adventurous. 🍷



ISBN-13:
978-0356511368

Pages:
416

Publisher:
Orbit

Author:
Tade Thompson

Available:
hardback
paperback
ebook
audio

Rosewater

Winner of the Clarke Award this year, Tade Thompson’s *Rosewater* is the first in the Wormwood trilogy. It tells the story of an alternative future with a transformed Nigeria playing host to an alien dome, right in the centre of the eponymous new city.

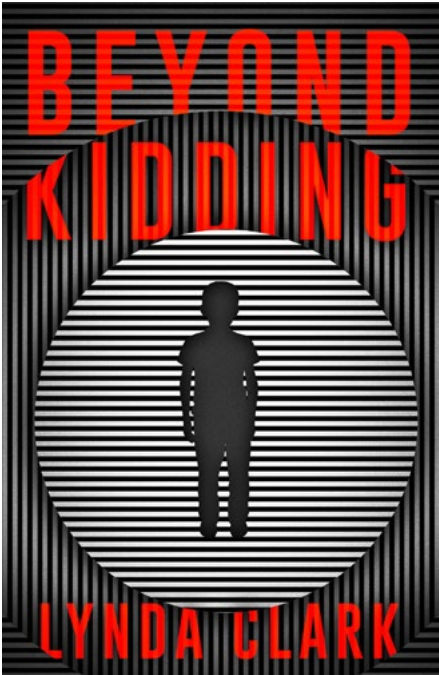
Kaaro is a government agent, working for Section 45. He is a ‘sensitive’ — a human who has become a telepath after being exposed to alien biology and has access to the ‘xenosphere’ (an illusionary shared mental space that seems to work like a shifting virtual reality). Kaaro is our narrator, telling us the story in a patchwork series of current events and flashbacks, all clearly marked with a date and time.

Thompson has said that his writing perspective is all about character and the Clarke Award judges agreed, commenting that *Rosewater’s* treatment of characters is incredibly engaging. There are small narrative arcs and developments for many of the book’s cast and even its locations. *Rosewater* itself is clearly a character, and its gradual development from the arrival of the aliens to the resolution of the story is a larger reflection of the development of the individuals who live there.

Kaaro himself is fascinating. Thompson eschews the traditional attributes of a hero, making his protagonist a little sexist and something of a coward. The dialogue between him and his contemporaries is varied and interesting, making the world believable with its mundane qualities and its tense moments. In the majority, Kaaro’s sexism comes across in banter, which generally sees him go unrewarded for his misogyny. However, the female characters around him see something deeper in the way he acts, as opposed to how he talks. There is a generosity of spirit to him that appeals both directly to the reader and indirectly through the supporting cast. Whilst he is afraid, he confronts his fears, rather than running from them. He makes mistakes too, which for the most part, he regrets. At the end of the novel, you cannot help but look back and marvel at the varied and interesting series of events that has brought Kaaro to be in such a pivotal position in *Rosewater’s* story.

However, Thompson’s character focus does come with a cost. At times, the plot of *Rosewater* seems to meander and disappear. Events do not build towards anything; Kaaro has tasks that he has been given to do, but they are pushed away at times and some of the chaotic encounters he deals with do not connect to anything else. The continual back and forth of date and time is clearly marked but can mean the reader loses track of what is happening and in what order. Much of the conclusion relies on Kaaro calling in a favour from more than a decade ago, which the reader doesn’t find out about until the chapter after it is mentioned — which feels less like a Chekov’s gun and more a *deus ex machina*.

Rosewater is an excellent read. The setting and the characterisation mark it out as being an innovative novel. There is clearly much more to the mysteries of Wyrnwood, Section 45, The Bicycle Girl and the alien biodome, which will be explored in Thompson’s subsequent books.



ISBN:
9781912054848

Pages:
328

Publisher:
Fairlight Books

Author:
Lynda Clark

Available:
paperback
ebook

Beyond Kidding

Beyond Kidding is heavily grounded in the (ab)normal life of the protagonist, Rob, a nearly-thirty underachiever working in a sex shop owned by his childhood best friend ‘Bummer’. After a series of setbacks Rob decides that he needs a better job to springboard his life into adult status. Part-way through bungling the interview he bonds with the boss of the company by mentioning that he’s a single parent raising his seven-year-old son, Brodie. Later, to avoid an awkward situation, Rob claims that Brodie has been kidnapped, which then starts a chain of events that leads to Brodie being found. The only issue is that Brodie never existed — Rob made him up.

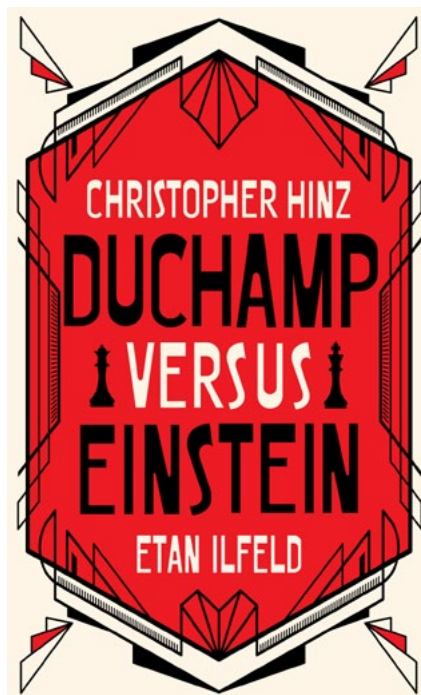
The majority of the story is told in a series of flashbacks as Rob desperately bears his soul to his friend Jules about everything that lead to him concocting a fake child. By this stage Rob is on the verge of madness because everyone — even his friends and family — remembers Brodie too. This in itself makes a good story, reminiscent of the best of *The Twilight Zone*, but layered on top of that the boy-that-shouldn’t-exist sits literally in the next room while Rob narrates the whole thing to Jules, which feels pleasingly claustrophobic. Clark manages to convey just how oblivious Rob is to his own role in his life’s twists and turns while keeping the narrative flowing and easy to follow. If I have one criticism here, it’s that the story feels like a novella that’s been padded into novel form. The climb to midway feels a little long given its flashback-nature. However, this is a minor point, and once I’d made it to around halfway *Beyond Kidding* really got moving and I found myself at the end rather suddenly.

At times *Beyond Kidding* is cringe-worthy bare-naked honesty, and other times verging on surreal — and yet somehow it comes together smoothly. Rob’s haphazard logic and leap-before-looking nature feel authentic to the point where the reader might well wonder exactly how much is taken from personal experiences! Clark’s style reminds me of Phoebe Waller-Bridge’s *Fleabag* if she’d decided to co-write it with the ghost of Douglas Adams.

Despite enjoying the story, I couldn’t help wishing that Rob had *some* redeeming qualities that would allow me to empathise with him a little more. Clark doesn’t shy away from warts-and-all descriptions of Rob’s (entirely juvenile) thoughts and actions; her writing is expressive, which beautifully paints just how terrible Rob is as a friend, colleague, partner, and general human being. Fortunately Rob’s support network seems to have enough moral fibre to go round — which is handy because he’s now a dad to a child that shouldn’t exist, and he’s going to need help figuring all this out.

Words:
Allen Stroud,
Louis Calvert,
Tom Grundy

Design:
Angus McNicholl



ISBN:
9780857668349

Pages:
88

Publisher:
Angry Robot

Author:
**Christopher Hinz,
and Etan Ilfeld**

Available:
**paperback
ebook**

Duchamp Versus Einstein

What if a transcendent alien intelligence made Marcel Duchamp and Albert Einstein play chess together? This is the premise of the pleasingly-named *Duchamp Versus Einstein*, a new novelette co-written by Christopher Hinz and Etan Ilfeld. The latter is director of the company that owns Angry Robot, the book's publisher.

The novelette is split into chapters which follow either titular protagonist through various episodes at different points in their lives, smartly and non-chronologically detailing their interactions with a starchild-like figure known as Stella.

The writing is neat, pithy, and clean. The characters themselves are written with sufficient nods to their real-world achievements and lives to spark recognition, but this doesn't veer into triteness. The dialogue, in particular, crackles with wit and intelligence; I have no idea what a conversation with Einstein would have been like, but these approximations are entertaining and plausible nevertheless. The book is at its best as a series of hypothetical conversations between improbable people, and contains some of the more memorable dialogue I've read this year.

However, it's weird. It doesn't seem to go anywhere. The reader finds themselves on the final page with surprise, just as a plot feels almost within grasp. There is a good sense that something weighty and important is being said here, possibly about the nature of war and fate and human nature and so forth, but you never get a clear sense of what this is. This is a lesser evil than going too far the other way, and shoving your point in the reader's face — and there are worse sensations than the lingering feeling that a book might just be too clever for you. But the reader might come away with more of a sense of closure were the book clearer about what it is trying to say.

It feels like there are two potential products here. A short story asking the whimsical question "what would a chess game between Einstein and Duchamp be like?" would make for a diverting twenty minutes. Likewise, a novel about an alien intelligence seeking to alter human history through interventions into the lives of people around the Manhattan Project would potentially make for a racy, thoughtful, and gripping read. This is something in between.

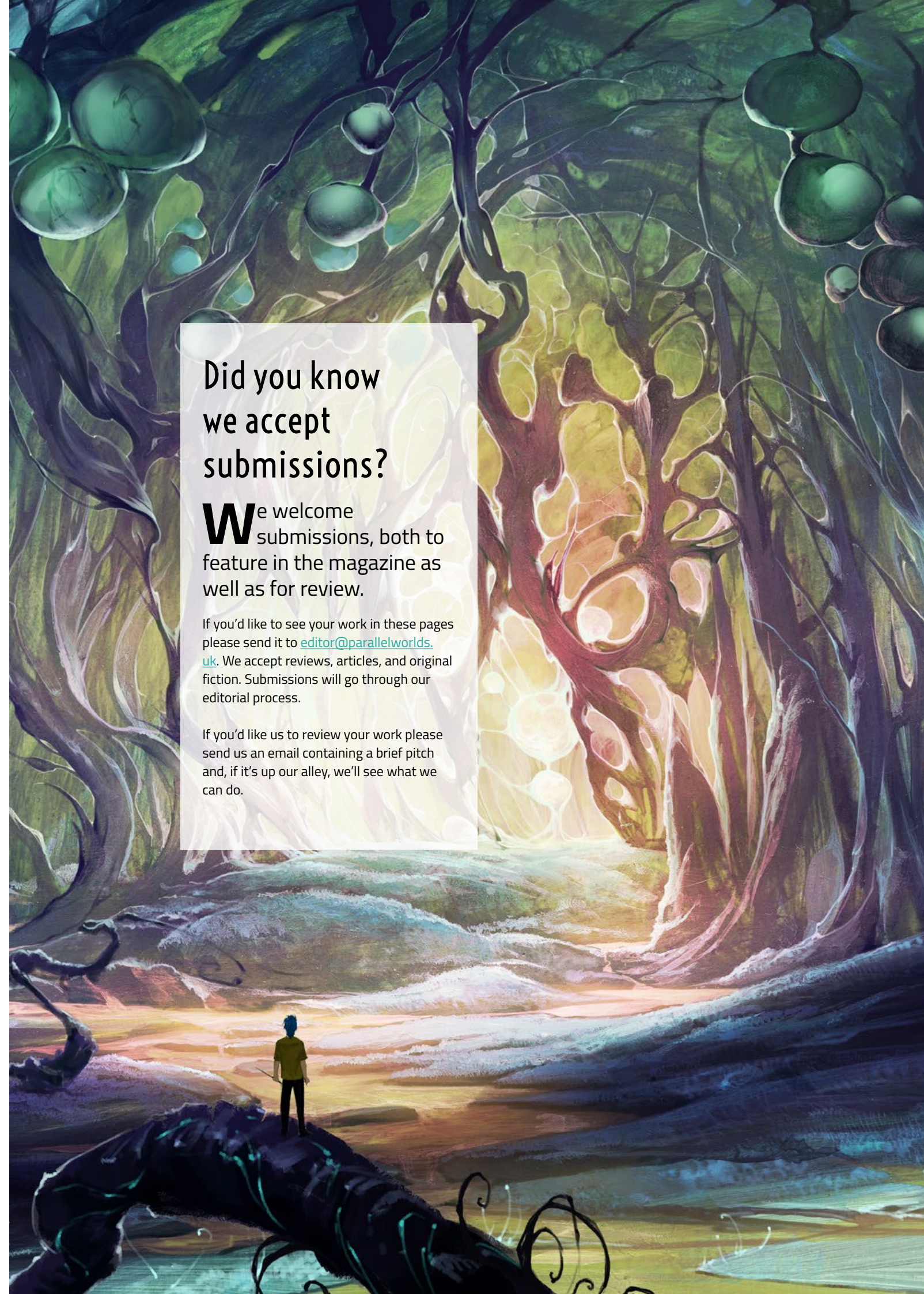
Duchamp Versus Einstein has a lot of merit. A meat-and-potatoes science fiction story it isn't — but if you're in the mood for a bit of whimsy, and are willing to suspend your expectations and pay attention, you may well be pleased you picked it up. 🍷

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fiction. Submissions will go through our
editorial process.

If you'd like us to review your work please
send us an email containing a brief pitch
and, if it's up our alley, we'll see what we
can do.



Words:
Ben Potts

Design:
Angus McNicholl

Art:
**David McNamara,
Angus McNicholl**

KEEPING TREK

PART 2

In the second part of our focus on *Star Trek*, we look back over the 1990s, 2000s, and the famous franchise today.

The 1980s saw *Star Trek* successfully transition to the cinema screen. However, the reliance on the same actors and characters would gradually take its toll, and whilst the six movies that focused on original *Enterprise* crew would continue until 1991, Gene Roddenberry, creator of the brand, had some other ideas up his sleeve.

Despite the failure of *Phase II* back in 1976, Roddenberry believed many of the ideas were still sound. He used the concepts as a launching point for what would become the franchise's next incarnation: *Star Trek: The Next Generation* (1987–1994). This was a momentous step forward for *Star Trek*, and a very different show than the original. Led by the more cerebral character of Captain Jean-Luc Picard, played by Patrick Stewart, this new series fleshed out the utopia of the 24th century. The pseudoscience of the show reflected its time, with a grounded set of technology that regularly became an integral part of the plot. Thanks to energy sources such as 'dilithium crystals' and the energy-to-matter converters known as 'replicators', vessels like the *Enterprise* could manufacture anything, including food and water. Thanks to the abundance of resources, money was no longer a concern; people worked to amass reputation, experience, and knowledge, rather than material wealth.

The cast was even more diverse than its predecessor. With LeVar Burton as the black Chief Engineer Geordi, and three female characters on the main roster at first, the show was making clear its intentions from the off.

Star Trek: The Next Generation continued with the allegorical storytelling of its predecessor, but also expanded its scope; its most popular storyline was the two-part episode 'Best of Both Worlds', which focused on one of science fiction's most terrifying enemies: the Borg. It was proof that *Trek* could be an inspirational and thoughtful franchise, while still throwing in the occasional heart-pumping thriller.

But there were problems too. Tasha Yar was killed off towards the end of the first season after her actor, Denise Crosby, resigned. There were rumours that this was due to her involvement with *Playboy*, but it turned out she simply wasn't enjoying the show. Meanwhile, the child character of Wesley Crusher had few fans, as viewers considered him irritatingly precocious and were reluctant to accept him as a genius who saves the day. His actor Wil Wheaton survived the hate and has gone on to become an internet icon.

“*Trek* could be an inspirational and thoughtful franchise, while still throwing in the occasional heart-pumping thriller.”

”

Roddenberry's health was failing, and in the sixth season, he passed away. From that point on, the show would continue without him. Before he died, however, he had been consulted about *Trek's* upcoming show, *Deep Space Nine*.

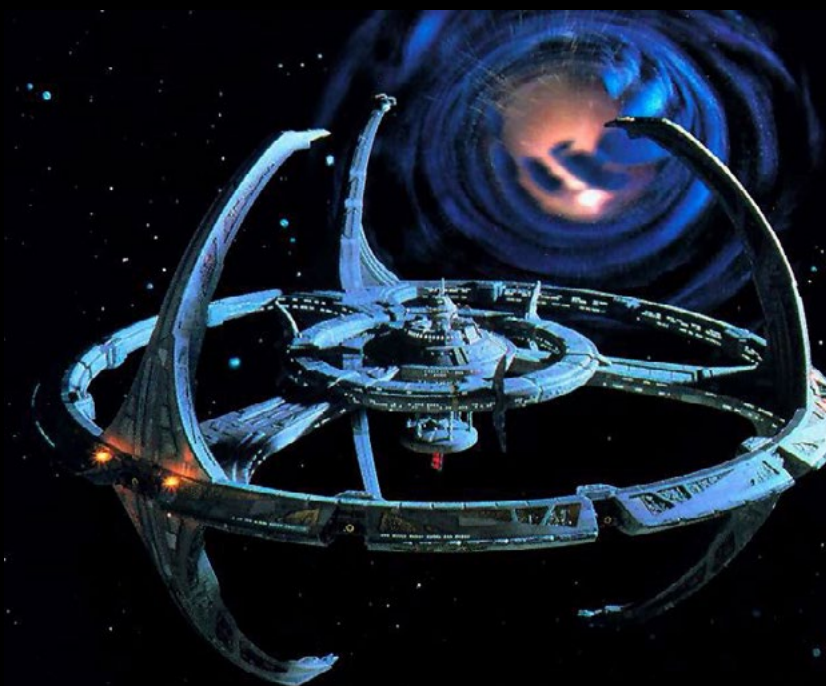
As with most visionaries, Roddenberry was hardly a perfect person — particularly when it came to women. Accounts from female *Star Trek* actors indicate that Roddenberry might not have fared too well in the #MeToo

era. He was also difficult to get along with, by some accounts, and many of his coworkers parted with him on less-than-positive terms. He took legal and illegal drugs both recreationally and as stimulants to keep working late into the night, which most likely contributed to his death.

Nonetheless, he possessed two key attributes that would help turn *Star Trek* into one of the most momentous media franchises of the 20th century. First: he

had an uncanny knack for predicting future trends. Second: He was fundamentally optimistic about the future, and believed humankind would grow beyond its struggles in the coming centuries. Racism, nationalism, religious hatred, and other forms of discrimination; he believed humanity would leave all of that behind. This optimism seems quaint in the light of today's 'grimdark' trend, although many believe it is what sets *Trek* apart from its contemporaries.

“
Deep Space Nine was notorious for its 'darker' storylines.
”



Star Trek: The Next Generation

Seasons: 7
Episodes: 178

Post-Roddenberry shows and franchise fatigue

Trek did not slow with the passing of its creator. *Star Trek: Deep Space Nine* (*DS9*) came to television in the early 90s, and was unlike any *Trek* show before or since. Instead of flying about on a spaceship, *DS9* was set on a space station in orbit around a planet named Bajor, near a wormhole leading to another section of the galaxy. The stationary setting allowed the showrunners to experiment with all manner of different kinds of stories, including serialised storytelling the likes of which had rarely been seen before. This makes it surprisingly binge-able in 2019. *DS9* was also notorious for its 'darker' storylines, in which the so-called utopia of the 24th century humanity was challenged.

Babylon 5, a show about a remarkably similar space station, also pioneered story arcs that played out over the course of a series rather than isolated episodes. Controversy surrounds the two series to this day: *Babylon 5* aired a few months after *DS9*, but was actually pitched to Paramount before being picked up by Warner.

Perhaps *DS9's* most-controversial creation was Section 31, a secret part of the Federation charged with carrying out the 'dirty work' that Starfleet was too 'squeamish' to do. Many fans loathed these additions as contrary to Roddenberry's utopian ideals, but others loved the risk-taking and deconstruction.

One of *DS9's* most popular aspects was its choice to cast a black man, Avery

Brooks, as Commander (later Captain) Benjamin Sisko. Like Nichelle Nichols and LeVar Burton before him, Brooks was an inspiration to a generation of African-Americans. One of the show's most popular and groundbreaking episodes was Season 6's 'Far Beyond the Stars', in which Sisko hallucinates an alternate life as a black science fiction writer in the 1950s. It was Brooks' favourite episode, and a damn fine hour of television. *DS9* made some strides forward in representation (it famously included a sort-of lesbian kiss in one episode), but showrunners later expressed regret with how little work they did promoting the inclusion of LGBTQ+ characters.

The Next Generation came to its end soon after *DS9* began, but the adventures of the *USS Enterprise D* continued with the *Next Generation*-era films. In 1994, *Star Trek Generations* was released, in which Shatner's Kirk returned and worked with Picard and his crew in a 'handing of the torch'-style plot. Several films appeared centered around the adventures of the *Next Generation* crew, but by 2002 and the release of *Star Trek: Nemesis*, viewing figures had slumped. *Nemesis* was a dismal failure and a death knell for any future *Trek* films — or so it seemed at the time.

In the meantime on television, following the end of *The Next Generation*, *Trek's* next incarnation was *Star Trek: Voyager* (1995–2001). After having a black captain, what was the next logical step for *Trek*?

A woman, of course. Kate Mulgrew was cast as Captain Kathryn Janeway, a leader and mother to a crew trapped 70,000 light years from home. At this point, *Trek* was suffering from franchise fatigue, and *Voyager* proved to be the least successful series to date. Storylines were arguably uninspired and some characters less-than-loved. The show found its stride a little bit at the start of Season 4 and the re-introduction of the Borg, with the casting of former model Jeri Ryan as the liberated Borg drone Seven of Nine. The move seemed to work. Seven of Nine was a fascinating character in her own right, although her form-fitting catsuits seem designed to attract male viewers.

Voyager declined in the ratings and ended with a whimper in 2001. *Trek's* next incarnation, *Enterprise* (it lacked the *Star Trek* prefix for the first two seasons, partly because it was a prequel), would be its last for more than a decade. Showrunners made a number of choices attempting to recapture the excitement of the fanbase: a white man, Scott Bakula as Jonathan Archer, was back in the captain's chair, and the first officer, female Vulcan T'Pol, was quite sexualised.

Enterprise had some interesting threads but they weren't enough to save it from an early end after only four seasons. Its cancellation in 2005 ended eighteen years of *Trek*, and seemed like a death knell for the series as a whole.



Star Trek: Deep Space Nine

Seasons: 7
Episodes: 176

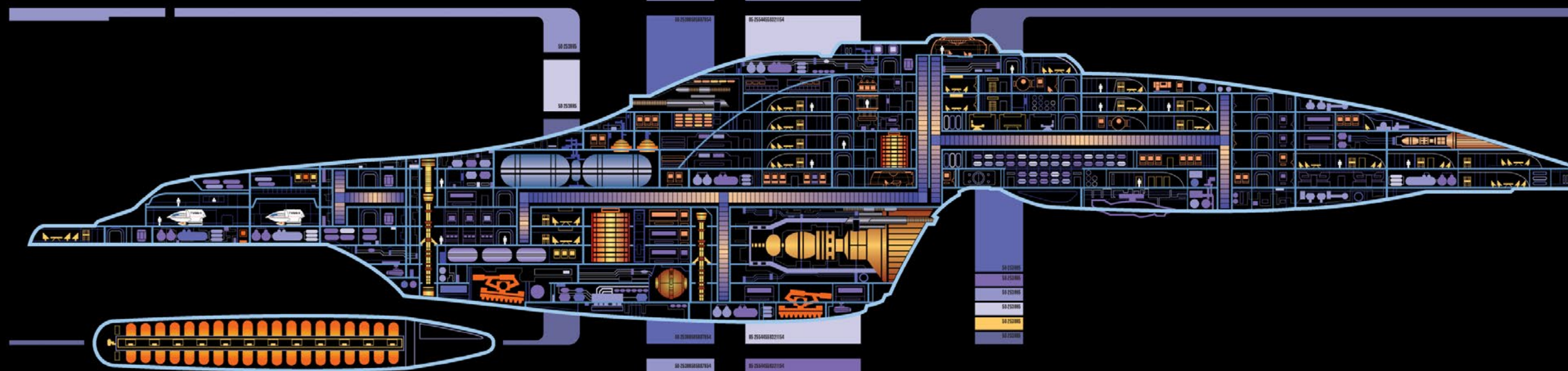
Star Trek: Voyager

Seasons: 7
Episodes: 172



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Recurring characters and actors

Trek has had a number of actors that keep returning to the series, either in their original roles or different ones. Perhaps the most well-known example is Majel Barrett, Roddenberry's widow. She started in *Trek*'s very first incarnation as Number One in 'The Cage', became Nurse Christine Chapel in *The Original Series*, and returned as Lwaxana Troi (the voracious mother of series regular Deanna Troi) in *The Next Generation* and *Deep Space Nine*. Barrett was further involved in the series as the voice of many starships' computer systems, from *The Next Generation* through *Enterprise*.

“For almost as long as there has been *Trek*, there has been tie-in fiction.”

Denise Crosby was another popular recurring actor. After leaving the role of Tasha Yar, she returned in later seasons in various roles, including an alternative universe's version of Yar and her half-Romulan daughter named Commander Sela. Never before had technobabble been so complex and disturbing!

Other popular recurring actors, many of whom remain popular at conventions, include Diana Muldaur in two minor roles in *The Original Series* and a one-season regular of *The Next Generation* as Dr. Pulaski; Marc Alaimo, whose prominent neck muscles were the inspiration for the infamous Cardassian neck design and who played multiple roles across incarnations of the show; and Jeffrey Combs, who at one point played two recurring characters (of different alien races) in the same episode of *Deep Space Nine*.



Non-canon *Trek* and fan content

For almost as long as there has been *Trek*, there has been tie-in fiction. Over the fifty-plus years since *The Original Series*, many hundreds of novels, anthologies, comics, and other forms of print *Trek* media have been released. They cover content from across every incarnation of the show and its films. These media are licensed in an interesting way, in that they are all considered non-canon. Many of them expand on the stories of popular guest characters, such as John de Lancie's omnipotent 'Q' and Majel Barrett's Lwaxana Troi. Notable successes include: Peter David's *Imzadi*, which expanded on the pre-*Next Generation* romantic relationship of William Riker and Deanna Troi; Vonda N. McIntyre's *The Entropy Effect*, which is more of a classic *Original Series* adventure; and Andrew J. Robinson's *A Stitch in Time*, which focuses on the popular character Garak he played on *Deep Space Nine* and was based on a biography he wrote for the character after being cast.

Trek media also includes an extensive non-fiction catalogue. Documentaries, analyses, and commentaries about the franchise abound, from the recently-released, fan-funded documentary *What We Leave Behind* about the much-maligned *Deep Space Nine* to 1997's *Trekkies*, a documentary helmed by *Next Generation* actress Denise Crosby about the franchise's legions of — at times quite eccentric — fans.

Some content, while not exactly *Trek*, clearly took inspiration from Roddenberry. From 2000–2005, alongside *Enterprise*, Majel Barrett and a Canadian-American team brought *Gene Roddenberry's Andromeda* to the television scene. It wasn't *Trek*, exactly, but borrowed from some of Gene Roddenberry's unused concepts, creating a far more dystopian science fiction series

starring Kevin Sorbo (of *Hercules: The Legendary Journeys* fame) as Captain Dylan Hunt.

Fan-produced video content has also become quite impressive in recent years. *Star Trek Continues* was a web series set on the original *Enterprise*, essentially taking over where *The Original Series* had left off. The show, partly funded by Kickstarter, starred professional actors and fans of *Trek* in the roles formerly occupied by William Shatner and others, and released eleven episodes from 2012 to 2017. Another fan-produced, Kickstarter-backed production was *Prelude to Axanar*, starring some *Trek* alumni in an attempt to demonstrate that quality *Trek* films could be made on a limited budget. The film was considered successful as a proof of concept.



“Abrams saw in *Trek* a kind of media similar to classical music: it could find a wider audience if it just added in a bit more jazz.”

The Abrams reboots and the modern series

Even those with little exposure to *Star Trek* are likely familiar with the franchise reboot by J.J. Abrams in 2009. Abrams saw in *Trek* a kind of media similar to classical music: it could find a wider audience if it just added in a bit more jazz. He cast younger actors as the original crew of the *Enterprise* and proceeded to make a blockbuster hit. The reboot was controversial among fans for a number of reasons, not least Abrams' notorious lens flares, but it created a surge of renewed interest in the franchise and lead to two more feature films and a new television series in 2017. The films added little to the franchise as a whole, save the razzle-dazzle of modern special effects, but were commercially successful. Interest waned as Abrams turned his attention to *Star Wars*, renewing tensions between fans of the two science fiction franchises.

This brings us to the present. A fourth film in the rebooted 'Kelvin' universe seems unlikely, but *Trek* lives on in the two television series currently in development under CBS all-access. *Star Trek: Discovery* has been out for two seasons, and after a lacklustre first season, seems to be finding its legs. *Star Trek: Picard* is coming soon with Sir Patrick Stewart returning as an older Jean-Luc Picard, following his retirement from Starfleet. For added nostalgia, Brent Spiner will be returning as *The Next Generation*'s Data, and Jeri Ryan will be returning as Annika Hansen, also known as Seven of Nine from *Voyager*. At the moment, *Discovery* seems to be leading

the way on the diversity avenue, with a black female lead and an openly gay crew member, while it is unclear what Picard will add to the table beyond a welcome return to the gentle wisdom of Stewart's captain.

It's an interesting time to be a Trekkie. It's yet to become clear what the place of the series is in 2019, as the optimism of Roddenberry's utopian vision and the allegorical roots of the series seem to have been supplanted by snazzy special effects and copious heaps of nostalgia. Nonetheless, for 50 years, *Star Trek* has been a cultural leader in television and an inspiration for those who hope for a future utopia.

“*Star Trek* has been a cultural leader in television and an inspiration for those who hope for a future utopia.”



Let's talk about...

Jim Henson's The Dark Crystal AGE OF RESISTANCE

We couldn't decide who should get to review Netflix's latest fantasy *tour de force* — so Tom gave his thoughts and then Allen and Beth Faulds, our guest contributor, responded. Tom is new to the franchise, Beth saw the original film in the cinema the first time around, and Allen has bumped up against the franchise once or twice in a professional context.

Tom:

The Making Of *The Dark Crystal: Age of Resistance* documentary, on Netflix, lines up the cast and crew of Netflix's new ten-episode fantasy prequel to the 1982 film to talk about how much the film meant to them and affected their childhoods. If they and similar coverage are to be believed, *The Dark Crystal* had a cultural impact similar to *Star Wars*.

It might have for the — apparently quite large — proportion of the production team with 'Henson' in their name. But for most other people, the 1982 Jim Henson film *The Dark Crystal* is mostly known for being a bit shit and less good than *Labyrinth*. That's certainly the impression I got when I watched it for the first time. An ambitious, dreamlike, poorly-plotted, and visually spectacular film, it puzzled critics upon release and has only gained 'cult' status in recent years, with the forgiveness that nostalgia brings.

Beth:

I disagree. If you were a child of the right age when it hit theatres or home video, *The Dark Crystal* movie was like a goddamn secret society. "You should watch this. Yeah, I know they're puppets, but trust me." The disgusting, disturbing Skeksis and the plodding, goody-goody Mystics. The Gelflings burdened with the task of saving the world. And, of course, when you're a kid, you tend to let the word salad world-building flow over you. As important, culturally, as *Star Wars*? Maybe not. But I was never so viscerally moved by any film. The baddies literally sucked the life out of the lower order beings! Characters were disintegrated, grotesqueries paraded across the screen. The darkness! The horror! And we could get away with watching it because — puppets! I suggest its cult status is a function of the indelible mark it left on so many of my generation. And it may, naturally, colour my view of the series somewhat.

“You should watch this. Yeah, I know they're puppets, but trust me.”

Allen:

Agree with Beth here. The film was a massive, seminal part of my childhood. The lack of impact by comparison to the *Star Wars* franchise was more down to the commercial deals done for toy lines, sandwich boxes, bedspreads and the like.

Tom:

The new series is a glorious, technicolour feast of original fantasy. There are a smattering of computer-generated bits, mostly to add life to action scenes and animate the puppets' rictus faces, but it is nearly all done the old-fashioned way. I can't imagine this making great waves in, say, 1990; but after twenty years of CGI gluttony, a fantasy story told mostly without computers is actually really refreshing.

Allen:

You're never going to see me complaining about people being consistent to an original vision. Brian Froud, the original artist, is a genius and *The Dark Crystal* was a massive showcase of his work which led to people around the world getting to see his ideas. I owned the visual story book as a child and I still have copies of the books they produced — *The Art of The Dark Crystal* is fabulous.

Tom:

The creature design is marvellous. The animal denizens of the mythical planet of Thra are inventively weird; think Guillermo

del Toro, but less scary. Jim Henson famously stipulated that the entire feel of his fantasy world had to be "not like anything on Earth" — and this has clearly carried through. In fact, there appears to be a (perhaps unwarranted) reverential approach to the original film that means that very few of the creatures *didn't* first appear in 1982.

It's stunning, in the same way *Stardust* was: incredible vistas of sweeping mountain ranges and verdant plains, locales that take your breath away.

Beth:

They've taken the limited palette of the original movie and gone wild. And yet, they've done it without really changing what you remember. This is probably another function of watching it when young enough to let imagination fill in all the blanks left by a lower level of technical skill than is possible today. They've fleshed out the world with an astonishing abundance of nature, culture, and technology.

In much the way *The Lord of the Rings* fleshes out the world of *The Hobbit*, this offering is a substantial and meaty bite, and still manages to have space for Fizzgigs.

Tom:

It is also spectacularly, crazily, prodigiously expensive. Netflix appear to have given the Hensons a blank cheque. Filming took place over 80 different sets. Every flower, blade of grass, tree branch, and butterfly was designed by someone, by hand. This makes every scene a visual delight.

But perhaps the best example of profligacy is the voice actors. The puppets are voiced by the likes of Mark Strong, Simon Pegg, Mark Hamill, and Helena Bonham Carter, amongst others. Sigourney Weaver pops in to narrate a few sentences at the series' opening. Despite having watched most films in which she's appeared, I didn't realise it was her — so any benefit her casting brings to the production must be in the big-name association.

Unless these stars were doing it for the love of the thing, this is a gratuitous expense. Natalie Dormer, for example, plays Onica, the bittiest of bit characters who appears in about two episodes as a bag-carrier for a slightly more memorable bit character. Why is she here? What about this forgettable extra demands the skills of a famous film actor? It is unclear what these (presumably expensive) Hollywooders add that a capable voice actor couldn't.

Beth:

I would ask the actors. Are they doing it for the cheque, or for the fact that this is a dream project? Simon Pegg nailed the Chancellor's simpering whimper in a way that can only have come from someone who knew what the 'love-to-hate' character meant to fans. Maybe it's just another notch on his belt in terms of being involved in every great franchise of our childhood (*Star Trek*, *Star Wars*, *The Chronicles of Narnia*... and plenty of others) as if Tim, his character from his TV series *Spaced*, got all his dreams granted at once. But in any case, how many of the big-name actors jumped at the chance because of love?

“This offering is a substantial and meaty bite, and still manages to have space for Fizzgigs.”

Words:
Tom Grundy
Allen Stroud
Beth Faulds

Design:
Yana Koleva

Allen:

Agreed. There's massive love for this project. It was seminal to people's childhoods. Simon Pegg's *Spaced* was a confession to his fandom and this is an extension of that, being a part of what he loved.

Tom:

A good point. Simon Pegg did an absolutely masterful job as the Chancellor, one of the series' best characters.

As for the story, though, it's the same dribblingly forgettable plot as usual: a little band of plucky, photogenic teenagers, set by a Gandalf analogue on a course to liberate the land. The Gandalf figure is the Aughra, an eminently-watchable huffing, stomping old crone, and another

“Every flower, blade of grass, tree branch, and butterfly was designed by someone, by hand.”

of the series' best characters. The heroes, however, are the sort of insipid paragons of virtue you come across in all claptrap of this nature; their only faults are non-faults like impetuosity or being too trusting, and as soon as they're introduced to each other they're best bloody friends, resulting in many a saccharine reference to the magic of friendship.

I don't want to be the snooty reviewer claiming every fantasy story has to be *Hamlet*. *Age of Resistance* isn't aggressively formulaic — Netflix are chin-juttingly proud of the 'strong female characters' they've included, which is fair enough, although 'strong' certainly doesn't mean 'believable and memorable' in this case. But it's still a missed opportunity.

The hero, Rian, has no discernable characteristics whatsoever. I watched him scamper winsomely across the land for ten hours of my life, and I couldn't tell you a single thing about his preferences, attitudes, fears or ambitions. What do I know about him? He's Sad That His Dad's Dead. Other than that, he's just the Male Lead from *nearly every other* adventure story ever to cross the Atlantic in this direction.

The same goes for the female leads, too. They're not characters, they're archetypes. And why do they have to be pretty and young? What would be so wrong with the sword-wielding hero being a bit fat, or queer, or old, or ugly — or anything

remotely interesting at all?

Beth:

If I had any criticism it would echo this. Every single lead female is white blonde. Even the Grottan, Deet, is just slightly green in skin and a bit messier of hair. But yes, having three sisters who were of the same clan and looked more or less the same could be confusing at times, especially at the start. Another criticism might be the amount of world-building that was top loaded into an introductory narration. Yes, there are seven clans, (three of which we have very little exploration of), but perhaps this could have been unveiled in less of an info-dump? It did make the first episode or two feel more dry and factual than emotional and engaging.

Allen:

I wouldn't be that harsh about the plot, but I would say it is a weakness and in many ways a vehicle for the characters and the events to come. It's surprising how much the nostalgia card plays here. The struggle of Jem and Kyra was desperate, the ending of their species so tragic and final. Despite the fact that we know the Doom of Gelflings is going to happen, there's a deep resonance to the fellowship and comradeship that connected with me in a way that otherwise, only *Lord of the Rings* is able to do.

“The Gandalf figure is the Aughra, an eminently-watchable huffing, stomping old crone.”

Tom:

The problem with strong archetypes like that is there's lack of moral nuance. The Gelfling are charming, wide-eyed Hobbits who spend their days being lovely to each other and making friends with woodland animals. The memorable 1982 villains, the Skeksis, look like zombie birds of prey, who shuffle their rotting carcasses around the set boasting about how nefarious they are. Grimdark this isn't — it's pantomime.

The series delights in killing off ancillary characters slowly and dramatically and expecting us to care. In one late episode, a decidedly B-list character carks it over the course of about an hour's screen time, after having a sword thrust through her. The death is drawn-out and melodramatic — but I barely remembered who the character was and she'd done nothing of note for the entire series. This could be a casualty of production and editing; storyboarded, this character could have been very memorable, with their own interesting arc and fleshed-out personality. Much of that, if it ever existed, has been left on the cutting-room floor, forcing us to watch a laboured death with no emotional skin in the game.

“I was never so viscerally moved by any film.”

Allen:

Yes, that wasn't a great moment in the plot. I think when they got people together they were struggling to deal with the ensemble and give everyone a role, plus killing off a character raises the stakes, right?

Tom:

Age of Resistance is full of this sort of thing. Expecting us to mourn a character they've made no attempt to flesh out; expecting us to recognise the 'bonds of friendship' between characters who have barely met; expecting us to be moved when a character loses a parent we've only heard four or five lines from. With a few exceptions, the characters are wooden, boring archetypes of the genre who spew wooden, boring lines. Think: "We've got to stop them!", "You'll never get away with this!" and so on. How is it that we routinely make series and films that are astounding in visuals, sound, and effects, but so painfully trite in character and plot? Whether this is a problem for you will really depend on whether you are content to be entertained, or ask to be *interested* too. You may not.

Beth:

It's a kid's film expanded into a series for adults and kids. I think the audience is going to need to set expectations accordingly. *Game of Thrones*, it isn't. But that's something to be relieved about, considering there are

puppets involved! There are plenty of childhood themes we all understood well enough when we were young: saving the world, sacrificing everything for friends, defying parental expectations... I found it interesting enough to watch all the way through without tuning out, and unlike many shows, I limited the number of episodes to watch per night so I could savour it more fully! But your mileage may always vary.

Allen:

I can certainly agree that there are a few well-budgeted productions that get funded for something other than the story. Here, the story of the series isn't its strongest element, although there are exceptions. SkekMal the Hunter is a new story, drawn from the novels, comics, and briefing materials from 2014. Whenever he's part of an episode, everything gains pace and tension.

Tom:

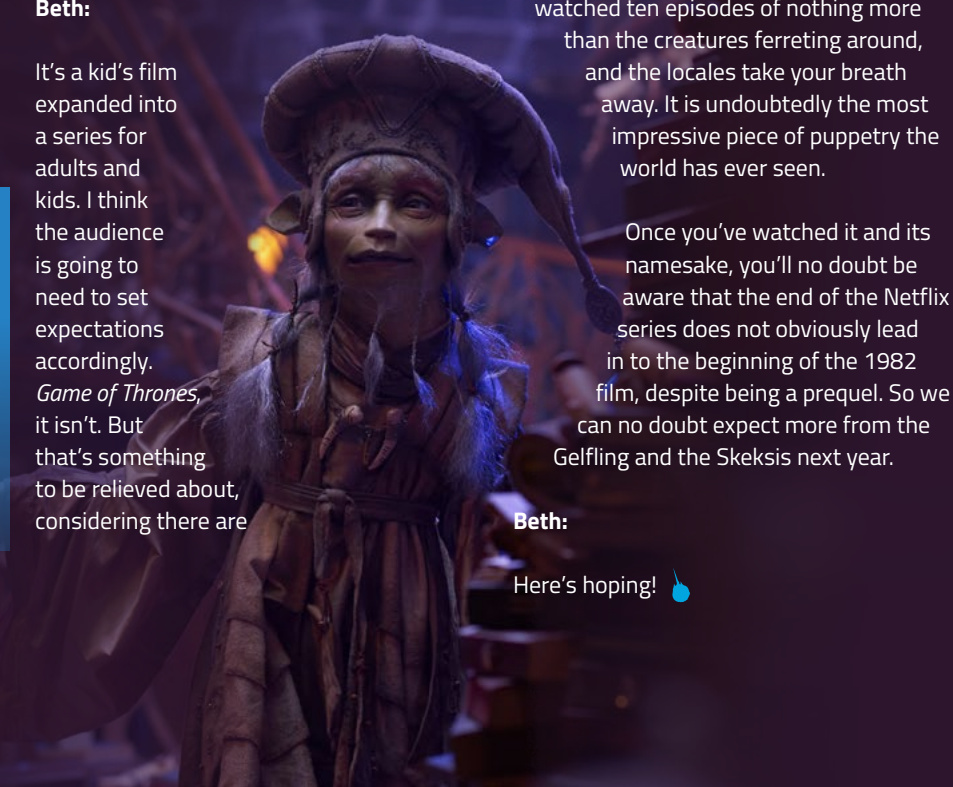
The duality of the Mystics and the Skeksis is definitely one of the series' narrative strengths, and that several of both are left unIntroduced only adds to the intrigue.

I do think the series tells its story spectacularly. I would have happily watched ten episodes of nothing more than the creatures ferreting around, and the locales take your breath away. It is undoubtedly the most impressive piece of puppetry the world has ever seen.

Once you've watched it and its namesake, you'll no doubt be aware that the end of the Netflix series does not obviously lead in to the beginning of the 1982 film, despite being a prequel. So we can no doubt expect more from the Gelfling and the Skeksis next year.

Beth:

Here's hoping! 🧡



ERDEN
FOE

Words:
**Mehzeb R.
Chowdhury**

Design:
Angus McNicholl

Art:
**warpaintcobra
santoelia**

The castle was decimated — a blackened and pockmarked shell all that remained, as if it had been the target of an air strike. Overhead, the maroon sky boiled and churned. Lightning flashed, thunder boomed. Flashes of electrical discharge revealing the ground underfoot in grizzly, illuminated horror. Blood and guts for carpet.

“Erden! Erden!” I dimly registered Yarmina screaming my name. The creature’s cries were deafening — years of artillery fire, gunshots at close range, and death metal music had never felt as loud as this.

The soldiers behind me kept firing, a cacophony of panicked cracks in the night. Agony drove me forward. I noted that I had lost part of my right arm, as if someone had taken a bite out of the muscle near the shoulder. My face was smeared in swiftly-cooling gore. Incandescent emerald eyes settled on me, muzzle flashes lighting its grotesque head in monstrous staccato. Something between frog, wolf, and crocodile, I would stammer later. A nasal cavity that looked underdeveloped.

Physical trauma has the odd effect of cementing trivial detail in high definition in your memory. A gust of wind tousled Yarmina’s grey pixie cut. She had highlights and her eyes were wide.

She had been right all along. We should never have entered the purple-hazed portal without reconnaissance. She was right most of the time, I privately acknowledged. There was enough of her “I told you so’s” already. I had adored her for years.

The gunnies at the base told me they had seen her with a pretty boy on shore leave. That outright disqualified me — I was anything but pretty. “Ain’t never gonna happen,” they would say, whenever I was caught stealing a glance.

During a bombardment, once, in the middle of the Southland rainforest, our carrier went down. Command ordered everyone to lay low until help arrived. Seven days we spent in each other’s company. It was the best 168 hours of my life. At the end of a night of stargazing outside the village, I finally gathered the courage to make my move. For a brief moment, she returned my stare. Then burst out in laughter. A friendly punch on the shoulder. “You’re such a goofball.”

When the portal appeared, she was the first one to loudly question a manned mission without drone reconnaissance. But the labcoats were sure — their scans showed no signs of danger. Their hypothesis was that it was some gateway to another world. Instead, we ended up only twenty miles from the base, facing a foe that wouldn’t die.

I returned to the awful present, shouting.

The beast opened its mouth, its jaw distending, unhinged, revealing teeth and gore. Its saliva splashed onto my face. It was warm, sticky, and smelled like rotten eggs.

“Hold on!” Yarmina directed the soldiers to cover her.

In a flash, the creature was upon me, and I was alone. A snaking tongue lashed out flicking across my face as I tried to dodge away. For some reason, it didn’t immediately tear me apart. It was as

though it was studying me. I was strangely calm, noting a small round object flying through the air towards us.

Grenade!

The blinding flash made the monster flinch, and I broke free, equally disoriented. Laser surgery had made my eyes sensitive to light.

I managed to scoop up my gun from the ground, but as I turned to aim it, my legs gave way and the world seemed to spin. I pointed it at the creature awkwardly, targeting an arm. My balance was off, and palms sweaty. But when the gun kicked reassuringly into my shoulder, I saw the grey limb arc cleanly away from the socket. Cyan blood. A hellish scream filled the night. Bizarrely, the noise made me think of the time I fell from the third-floor window of the family house, breaking my leg. A viscous, lumpy slime spilled out of the beast’s mouth. It smelled vile, like a dead rat covered in fresh vomit.

This time, the creature stepped back, clearly in pain and fearful of our weapons. Its cries of agony were oddly recognisable. Again, I thought back to my own experiences, that time I had been shot in the stomach on mission, and spent the whole journey back to base writhing in pain on the floor of the evacuation shuttle.

We were clearly winning. I took a few steps forward and so did others. Shouts of encouragement from Yarmina and her veterans rallied the troops, driving them on.

Then the creature picked up a boulder with impossible ease, and threw it at the regiment. I saw at least three soldiers go down and six more flee the scene. It was wounded, but still very dangerous. It arched its back and screamed out a cry of defiance to the heavens. Flashes of lightning spat across the sky in response. Then it crouched down and charged.

Straight at me.

I swallowed hard, but this time my hands were steady and I knew what to do. In one swift motion, I plucked a smart bomb from my belt and heaved it through the air and into the monster’s open mouth. The explosive lodged into its throat, and it began to gag.

“Run!” I yelled, punching a sequence of commands on my watch. As I followed the swiftly-retreating backs of the soldiers, I heard the detonation, and felt the muffled impacts as its gore peppered the grass.

“Portal!” Yarmina shouted. Looking up, I saw the window in the air shimmering erratically, much less stable than it had been when we entered.

“Go, go, go!” I ran towards it.

Everyone fled, sprinting for the distortion. As the last of the regiment fell through, back into normal daylight and fresh air, the purple hue dissipated and the portal winked out of existence.

The sun was shining brightly. As my eyes adjusted, the familiar lines of the base settled into view.

Later, the doctors looked me over with evident concern. A few hundred photos, half a dozen vials of blood, and a handful of x-rays. Yarmina sat watching from the opposite bunk, munching protein bars. A nurse stitched up the hanging bits from my arm and sutured the wound.

“Animal attack?” She busily applied the dressing.

“Something like that,” Yarmina answered for me.

“Could you give me something for the pain?” I asked quietly.

“I’ll ask the doctor.” She left the tent.

Yarmina slid off the bunk, picked up a cloth and wiped the side of my mouth.

“What are you doing?”

She frowned. “You’re dribbling. Can’t you tell?”

I was embarrassed. “Sorry.”

“Don’t worry. You look tired. We have a long day of debriefing tomorrow. Rest up.”

At chow time the following day, I sat quietly staring at my plate. Breakfast had tasted like a kitchen sponge, and lunch was no different. Yarmina watched me with concerned curiosity while sipping a diet soda.

“What’s wrong?” she asked in a low voice.

“Nothing.”

She leaned forward. “You’re sweating. And you clearly have no appetite. Something is definitely wrong. We have to go back to sick bay.”

“Let’s give it another day,” I stalled, swallowing my afternoon medication.

She stared levelly at me for a moment.

“What did you find out about the castle?” I asked, trying to change the subject.

“The database description reads like a horror novel. Monster sightings, strange disappearances, people seeing their dead relatives. If it’s something horrible, it’s happened at Dornham.”

“Anything from the squints?”

“You mean the scientists? Yeah, the brass sent a field team out to the castle on our side. They found unusually high levels of radiation and the electrical activity is off the charts. Nothing to explain the portal or the creature.”

“We should lock it down. Set up a perimeter.”

“It’s a popular tourist spot. The townsfolk won’t close it down without good reason.”

“Flesh-munching nightmare things don’t qualify?”

“That’s actually a selling point,” she smirked.

“What kind of world are we living in?” I mumbled.

Before Yarmina could answer, I felt my insides churning. A sharp sting at the base of my stomach. I gagged. My breakfast saw daylight. The retches forced everyone’s attention. Yarmina tossed me a paper towel and quickly dragged me out of the mess hall.

I passed out somewhere between the entrance to the barracks and my bunk bed.

In the evening, my team endured several rounds of interrogations. It was hard to explain what we had seen.

“What was it?” asked a colonel, for the fourth or fifth time.

“I honestly could not tell you, sir,” was my perennial response.

The base scientists were baffled by the portal, and could not offer us any explanation about it.

“What else can you remember?”

“That thing,” I started. “The creature. It was trying to communicate something.” I tried to explain what I felt I knew for the seventh or eighth time.

“Any idea what it was trying to say?”

“It wasn’t any language that I had ever heard. It wasn’t words, exactly.”

And so we got nowhere. The questions were repetitive, and the entire exercise tiring, but once everyone’s stories were down on paper and broadly matched up, the brass couldn’t think of anything else to ask us.

The following day, I asked Yarmina to look up Dornham Castle on the satellite scanner. She pulled up the logs and a live feed. It was standing tall, flawless. Being the town’s tourism cash cow, it was teeming with brightly-coloured anoraks and backpacks. But something at the back of my mind bothered me. It niggled at me. I felt that something bad was about to happen.

I had to see it. The arm that the creature had damaged was plastered up, immobile, so I couldn’t drive. My skin had gone an awful grey colour, almost greenish. Noises made me flinch, and anything brighter than the dim glow of the moon hurt my eyes.

If I was going to do something, it had to be soon — I felt sure I’d be quarantined before long. I requested a ride to the castle on a base transport.

The journey was awful. I sweated profusely.

“You okay, sir?” one of the escorting soldiers asked.

I nodded, dishonestly. No, I was not okay. I was running a fever, but also showing the symptoms of cyanosis. My fingers looked like they were swelling, under the fingernails. Somebody was playing Jenga with my internal organs. I turned over my hand.

“Oh my god,” I blurted.

“Sir?”

My palms were now grey, and my skin was coming away. Big flakes, like scales. I realised that my breath smelled. Halitosis. Disgusted, I started panic breathing. Suddenly, my tongue felt swollen. A godawful rumble in my stomach.

“Stop the transport,” I said, in a voice that was not mine.

When they did not, I panicked. I scrambled at the door handle. I couldn’t seem to grasp it, so I hurled my weight against it. It sheared off the hinges. I leapt out. I felt my clothes constricting me, and heard the tear of cloth.

“What the —,” I tried to say, but the sounds came out unrecognisable. I was a prisoner inside my own body.

A frightened soldier fired two rockets from the roof-mounted cannons of the transport. They missed me widely, but I heard the crack and tumble of masonry as they struck the castle. Limestone and wood scattered around me. I turned to see the castle ruined, the tourists and visitors blown away. Grisly remains littered the ground.

Then the transport disappeared.

Suddenly, the sky darkened. Mauve, then maroon. Web-like shapes danced in the roiling clouds as thunder rolled. My body was bulging, changing, grotesque. My fingers ached as bones lengthened, bursting from my fingertips.

As I felt my humanity ebbing away I saw a bizarre rent in the air, behind where the transport had been. The air around it shimmered purple. Silhouettes within. Then from it emerged a man who looked exactly like me, a clutch of soldiers at his back, and Yarmina.

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